all according to plan

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by FingerCracc

Summary

"She’s pretty, isn’t she? And you’re probably the only person on this planet that can touch her. What if she gets the wrong idea, or something? What if you…”

An incredulous laugh bubbles up in Mydei’s throat, but he bites his tongue to keep it down. “Are you stupid?” he asks, putting his free hand on Phainon’s hip and pressing him back. One step, two, they stumble. He pushes Phainon into the door, coming close. “Do you think I fall in love with everyone I meet?”

“How could you?” Phainon asks, unsteady, hands flexing on Mydei’s waist. “When you didn’t fall in love with me?”
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A mission gone awry, their leader kidnapped, a girl with the power to hurt everyone she touches. Mydei just wants to sort things out with his almost-but-not-quite boyfriend.

Notes

to my best friend in the world, happy birthday and here it is: Chrysos Buddies ft. Bubbles the Catmera for your reading pleasure!! good luck on your adventures, stay cool, I love you <3

to everyone else, there are some heavy topics mentioned but not explored in depth enough for me to tag, like kidnapping, drugging, human trafficking, gun violence, killing, and torture. It sounds super heavy but this fic is mostly lighthearted, also incredibly handwavey... don't take it too seriously. this is a rework of an abandoned wip for an old fandom so if some things are exceptionally silly, that'll be why. please enjoy <3

Mydei's first mission in ages turns out to be kind of a mess. Cipher wakes him up at four-thirty in the morning, and he isn't expecting it. He isn't taken on missions often. The last time was at least a month or two ago, and even then he only sat in the getaway car. *Just in case,* Anaxa told him. *You're here just in case they need you.* But they didn't. They're a capable bunch, and they rarely do.

He doesn't have super strength like Phainon or enhanced senses like Aglaea or Cipher's short-ranged teleportation. *You have more… specific applications,* Cipher likes to tell him, *You're our trump card. Every good heist needs a trump card!*

And Mydei gets it, he does. He's life or death in the situations where he's actually needed. It doesn't make sense to send him up against powers he can't counteract. Mydei is trained in combat, sure, and is damn good at it, but up against someone with strength like Phainon or speed or elemental abilities or something else along those lines, he's at a dangerous disadvantage. Not helpless, but not the best choice for the job either. So they keep him back even if it pisses him off, and he gets it, he does.

Today, though, is different. Today is one of the rare days when Mydei gets to be useful. Cipher shakes him awake from a restless sleep, her expression a bit manic and overexcited. Mydei sits up and gets this nervous thrill. Stage fright and anticipation at once. Even if he's been training forever, his experience out on the field is still considerably limited.

"Aglaea's fine," is the first thing Cipher says. The whole point of the original mission was to rescue her from the Cleaners. They left late last night, leaving Mydei to stay back and try to sleep. He was too pissed and anxious to get anywhere, though, and now he's here. *Needed.*

"We got her back," Cipher continues, voice hushed and secretive even though there's no one here to listen in. They check their flat for taps every other week. "it's just..."

Mydei pushes his blanket off. "Just...?"

"You'll see," Cipher says, grinning. "I called Anaxa and he’s got the car. Bring your shit. We need to get everyone out of there before they can catch us."

Mydei grabs for the bag where he keeps his gear for easy access and follows Cipher out in socks and his pajama pants, taking the elevator down to the ground floor. The car is idling out front, Anaxa looking bored in the driver's seat. Mydei climbs in the back, Cipher takes passenger.

"Explain," Mydei prompts, digging his undershirt out of the bag. It's black, skintight and long-sleeved, and he struggles into it, switching his pants for a pair lined with pockets and a holster to secure his handgun. Anaxa pulls away from the curb, and Cipher folds her arms around the back of her seat to look at him, her hood falling over her eyes before she lifts it, eyes glinting ominously.

"We found Aglaea is the shipping yard like Tribbie expected," she says, "but we had to look through an awful lot of containers to find her…” Her canines glint. “There was another girl in one of them. She's…”

"Dangerous," Anaxa cuts in gruffly.

"Scared," Cipher says instead. "She's tied up and drugged as much as Aglaea is, but she wouldn't let anyone come close. She kept saying she was going to hurt us."

"Dangerous," Anaxa says again. The car goes over a bump. Mydei catches himself on Cipher's seat, quickly doing up the buckles on his body armor.

"You weren't there, Professor," Cipher argues. "You didn't see her. She wasn’t threatening us, she was genuinely terrified… Boy do I love a good mystery like this one.” She turns to Mydei behind her again, tail beating against the seat. "We tried to take her with us, but Phainon got burned when he touched her.”

Something twists in Mydei’s gut. “That dumb fuck,” he curses. “Is he okay?”

“Fine, assuming we can get them out on time,” Anaxa tells him. “But the girl is dangerous. Taking this lightly would be folly.”

"She kept telling us not to come closer,” Cipher says drily. “It’s not like she was *trying* to hurt him. That Deliverer kid is just dumb.”

Anaxa is silent. Mydei shoves his hands into his gloves and digs his boots out of his bag last. His stomach flips and flips and flips. Strife, all the time they’ve made him sit on the sidelines must have turned him into a coward. "And that's where I come in," he says.

"Yeah," Cipher agrees, tipping her head over the back of the seat to look at him now, ears twitching. She isn’t wearing her seatbelt, and Anaxa is scowling. Another feline grin, twin finger guns pointed his way. “Trump card.”

Mydei takes a breath and secures his gun to his waistband. "Wonderful," he says, loading up his pockets with the essentials. Phainon burnt, Aglaea drugged up, some strange girl begging them to stay away. What *happened* with this mission? Things never go awry like this with Aglaea leading them. Her capture screwed them all over. When he's done gearing up, he settles back and finally buckles his seat belt. Anaxa speeds at least twenty miles over the limit.

"You've got this," Cipher tells him, still holding up the finger guns. She doesn’t act like it, but she’s older, and she's been on so many more missions than Mydei has. She and Aglaea were a duo before they picked the rest of them up like strays. Aglaea was the brains, Cipher did the dirty work.

Mydei has maybe a dozen missions to his name but they seem to have full faith in him. That, or they’re just desperate. Either way, he manages an expression that’s much more confident than he feels and says, “Of course I do.”

The shipping yard is just a sea of cargo containers and more cargo containers. Anaxa can't drop them off too close for fear of attracting attention, so Cipher leads the way as they walk, checking in on her in-ear.

"They're still secure," she murmurs after a moment, keeping a close eye on their surroundings. "Phainon says Aglaea can hear us."

"Isn’t she drugged?" Mydei asks, feeling the crunch of gravel under his boots, starting to remember what the mission scene feels like. Settling in, better than he’d worried he would. It’s always like that. He’s a quick adapter. He has to be, after everything he’s been through.

“Yeah,” Cipher replies, but offers no further explanation. A little further, she knocks thrice on the door to one of the shipping containers. It creaks open, and there's Phainon and Aglaea inside. Phainon is in gear, all tight black from head to toe, straps and buckles securing everything in place. His expression is far more severe than Mydei is used to seeing. Nothing like the eager golden retriever he is when he comes home after a successful mission. Not quite the stubborn determination of a spar either. No, he’s serious now, brows set, gaze dark. A smear of dirt on his cheek, hair a mess. Looking at him brings back the odd flipping in Mydei’s stomach.

They haven’t had a chance to talk much. Not since things got weird. Not since things got real. He hears Phainon’s inhale, and then he tears his gaze away.

Aglaea looks a bit worse for wear, her dress dirtied and torn at the hems. There are bruises on her cheekbone, scratches and scabs on her shoulders and arms. Her pupils are dilated wide enough to swallow her irises, but Mydei knows she can’t see a thing, not the way the rest of them can. She isn’t speaking, and he gets the sense that anything she might say will be cryptic and strange.

"She's two containers over," Phainon murmurs, ushering them in. His fingers have been hastily bandaged, Mydei notices. Burned, but not irreversibly, from touching this girl. Quietly, he slips around the door, circling Mydei’s arm with his good hand. His touch is cold, softly squeezing. *Alive,* Mydei thinks, gaze glued to him. He’s fine, but they’re on a mission, and nothing else he’s been worrying about is important in the meantime. Phainon turns to the other two. "Cipher, stay with Aglaea. Get her out of here if something happens. Mydei, let’s go.”

They slip out of the shipping container, shutting the door behind them as soundlessly as they're able. “Deliverer,” Mydei whispers.

Phainon only looks at him for a moment, gaze flicking between his eyes before he turns away. “Later,” he says, lightly pulling Mydei along. His grip loosens and slips off. Mydei catches his hand, squeezes it, waits for the edge of his smile in the night. *We're okay,* it says. *Don't worry about that much right now.*

The nerves come back as Phainon leads the way, softly padding through gravel, carefully checking every which way.

The door to the right shipping container is chained shut, and Phainon quickly undoes it, the links clattering, ginger with his hurt fingers. "She's scared," he says quietly. "Drugged worse than Aglaea. We need to keep her calm if we're going to get her out, or she'll just alert the Cleaners."

"She hurt you,” Mydei notes.

"Not badly," Phainon says, holding up his hand. The bandages on his fingertips are stained gold with his blood, but he smiles. “If something like this was enough to bench me, I'd hardly be worthy of being your equal.”

It's still not entirely clear what happened to him, what exactly this girl did. They wouldn't have brought Mydei out if it were elemental magic or some kind of attack. So what is this, what is *she?* "Why didn't you just bring Aglaea back and get treated? Why wait for me to come out?" Mydei asks.

"It's faster to send Cipher than to make Tribbie drive here and back,” Phainon says simply, setting the chains down as quietly as he can. He turns to Mydei with this strong gaze, and Titans, he cares about too much, doesn't he? The weight of the world stubbornly on his shoulders, like he thinks it makes him some hero to cling to everyone's hopes but his own. "We're bringing her back," he says firmly.

“What's so special about her?” Mydei asks, frustrated, almost. Because Phainon is hurt, because this is the only mission he's been sent on in

months, and he doesn’t even know what he’s here for. They could have left, nothing to it. Why does this matter?

“We’re all strays, Mydeimos,” Phainon says softly, taking Mydei’s hand again and pulling it to his mouth. “She needs help, same as the rest of us did at one point or another. Please.”

Mydei doesn't have the full story. He only knows what he's been told, which is barely anything at all, but maybe that’s all there is to know right now. He can't comprehend why Phainon might feel this strongly about bringing back someone who could very well be an enemy, but... He’s sure, and Mydei trusts him with everything. Even Cipher seems half invested in taking this girl home. He sucks in a breath and nods. Phainon nods back and drops his hand.

"Take her to Anaxa’s car. The rest of us will go with Tribbie."

"Alright," Mydei says, setting a hand on the door handle. Phainon steps back, edging into the shadows. "You're not coming?"

"I'll be out here," he says, reaching to rub his neck. "She keeps crying when she sees me."

"Oh."

An awkward smile, an awkward laugh. There he is, in the flesh. Mydei could be sick with it, sick with him. "Yeah."

Slowly, Mydei pulls the door open. There's a flashlight in one of his pockets. He pulls it out and clicks it on before he ducks inside, pulling the door half-closed behind him. A girl with hair long enough to pool on the floor where she sits and golden blood on her ragged white dress winces against the brightness and shrinks into the corner. Her hands and knees are bound, and she looks a hundred times worse than Aglaea does. Worse for wear. Terrified. Hungry.

A stray, like the rest of them. Mydei takes one look at her and gets it. Maybe he’s not the most selfless and compassionate of their bunch, but he

gets it.

He wonders where she came from, why she's here. Was she kidnapped like Aglaea was? He steps a little closer.

"No," the girl rasps, pulling her knees in. Her voice is rough, like she's been crying. Mydei can't see her face very well, just the point of her chin and her dry, cracked lips. Her bare feet on the cold, hard metal of the shipping container. "Don't," she says when Mydei takes another step. She sounds so scared. "I'll hurt you like I hurt your friend."

Slowly, Mydei sits down a few feet away from her, and she squeezes far enough into the wall to move farther from him that it must hurt. Her whole body must ache from the binds and her position. Mydei isn't so nervous anymore. His throat clicks as he swallows. "What's your power?" he asks. "Fire control? Or... heat? Something like that?"

Silence. The girl's eyes are closed. She’s shaking. After a long moment, she asks, "Are you going to kill me?"

Mydei doesn't know what to say to that. "No," he offers, and Titans, he *gets it* now. A lot of them start out like this. Lost and abused and afraid. Mydei started out like this too, half-drowned and unable to trust a soul after his own father threw him into the sea. "No one's going to hurt you," he promises.

A beat. The girl's eyes peel open, dazed and dilated, considering, and then they close again. "You're going to kill me," she says like she's sure of it. "I'm okay with it." She's got narrow, sloped shoulders, a head that hangs down like she has something to be ashamed of, choppy bangs obscuring her face. She seems so sad. More than scared, she just seems sad, tired of whatever kind of life she’s been forced to live.

"No one's going to kill you," Mydei insists. Blood on her dress, but not a single scratch on her. Where Aglaea had been scraped and bruised, this girl's skin is pale and untouched. Closer, there’s a print on her shoulder... fingers, maybe. Phainon's, from when he grabbed her and got hurt. Is it just her skin, then? Her touch?

"What's your name?" Mydei tries to ask instead.

The girl lifts her head. Her hair is a mess, tangled and matted, but a soft, pale pink color. Her eyes are big and wary. She looks so dazed and exhausted, but more resigned than scared now. Like she really thinks Mydei is going to kill her. Like she really is okay with that. "Castorice," she finally says.

"Castorice," Mydei repeats. "I'm Mydei."

"Okay."

"Could you tell me about your power?"

She looks at him blankly. "I hurt everyone I touch," she says, the words stringing together a bit, wavering at the edges.

Likely nothing elemental, then. Mydei sucks in a breath. "Could I untie you?" he asks.

"You'll touch me," she says. There's a long pause. "You'll get hurt."

She's in a long dress and gloves tall enough to cover her wrists beneath the bonds. "Even through your clothes?" Mydei asks. A silent nod. Mydei watches her for a moment. He thinks about Phainon's bandaged fingers, his insistence that this girl come with them. "Okay," he says, lifting a hand. "Can I test something?"

Castorice shrinks back even further, if that's possible. The way she does it is slow, kind of delayed. Mydei has no idea how long she's been here. She must need food and water to get the drugs out of her system, but she's clearly weak and dehydrated. Mydei needs to get her out of here quickly.

"No," Castorice slurs. "Don't— Don't touch, you'll hurt... I'll hurt you."

"Other people’s powers don’t affect me," Mydei tries. Or, many don’t. He never knows which ones until he comes into contact with them. Hence why he rarely goes on missions. He's a last ditch effort in an emergency. "Yours

won’t either." Or he'll end up with fried fingers like Phainon's, but he'll survive. It'll hurt, but he'll survive. "Can I try?"

"Don’t, please."

Mydei grits his teeth. *Be calm,* he tells himself. Yelling won’t help, his fists won’t help. He’s too used to solving problems by force. Habits are hard to break. *Be gentle.* But his patience is running thin, and their time is running out. "So... What's your plan, then? Just staying here forever? Hanging out all tied up until the bad guys come back for you? Or did they really just leave you here to die?"

Castorice's face changes at that. She looks scared again. Mydei wonders so many things about her. He has more questions than answers. She swallows thickly. "How do you know I'm not one of them?" she asks, strangely sober.

"You're tied up and trapped in a shipping container," Mydei points out, drier than he intends. “Why would you be one of them?”

Castorice opens her mouth, closes it again. Her head falls back into the wall. She's still making herself so small it must be painful. "Different bad guys, then."

Mydei considers that, has been considering that. "You don't want to hurt me or my friends," he says finally. "Bad guys usually want to hurt people."

A beat. Two, three. Phainon waits outside, just a breath away in case something happens. Aglaea might be listening, a couple containers over, if she’s well enough for it. Someone would say something if there was a problem. They still have time, but he has no idea how much. He’s good with head-on confrontations, not time limits and hiding.

Castorice looks at him, gaze foggy. She's dangerous, but she seems safe. She hurt Phainon. She could hurt Mydei too, but she might not. She wouldn’t mean to if she did. Either way, they need to get her out of here as quickly as possible. Mydei doesn't know her story, but he agrees with the rest. They can't leave her here.

And titans, he doesn't *want to.* For some reason he cares—if only a little bit—like Phainon and Cipher do. A breath. There's only one way to find out if Mydei will be immune to her power or not. Quickly, he taps Castorice on the leg. It makes her flinch like she'd been stabbed instead of poked, but there's no pain on Mydei's end, no blood, no injured fingers.

"No," Castorice says anyway. "No, no, why would you—"

"I'm not hurt," Mydei tells her, displaying his hand. It's gloved, so it doesn't prove much. Castorice presses herself as far away from him as she can get, tucking her limbs out of the way as best as she can. Mydei almost feels guilty. He scoots back to give her more space.

"Castorice," he says, trying to be patient. "You didn't hurt me."

"I—" At this, Castorice squints, face scrunching up like her head hurts trying to comprehend that.

Slowly, Mydei pulls off his gloves and displays his hands again, entirely unscathed. "Look," he says, and after a confused moment, Castorice does. "I didn't lie; your power doesn't work on me."

"You..." She's staring. Slowly, awkwardly with her arms bound behind her back, she peels away from the wall so she can see better in the terrible lighting. "You aren't… hurt?"

"No," Mydei says, offering a sharp smile. "Can I untie you now?"

Castorice's gaze flicks up to his face. She thinks about it for a long while, but Mydei doesn't push. He waits until gingerly, Castorice pushes her legs in his direction. "Don't touch," she says, wincing away before Mydei's hands can even come close. She braces herself for it, and Mydei wonders how old she was when her power presented itself. How many people she's hurt with her touch to be so afraid of it. He's careful to avoid her skin as he unties her.

"Will you come with us?" he asks, pulling the rope about Castorice's ankles free. "I promise no one will kill you."

She shifts so Mydei can get her wrists, stiffens when Mydei accidentally brushes against her gloves. So scared of it. So unused to it. Mydei didn't even touch her properly.

"Your friend," Castorice starts, fingers twitching. "I hurt him."

"Phainon's fine," Mydei tells her, "bandaged up and everything already. You could hit him with a truck and he'd get up after." Quiet. Castorice's wrists go free, and she pulls them into herself, massaging their aches. "He's dumb, huh? Should have listened when you told him not to touch."

Castorice doesn't nod, like she's afraid of agreeing. Like she thinks it's her fault, even if Phainon is the dumbass who didn't listen. Mydei should stop thinking so much. "We want you to come with us," he says. "Help get the drugs out of your system and give you a place to sleep for the night, at least."

She watches him, quietly considering, and then nods. "For the night," she echoes.

"Longer, if you want," Mydei says as gently as he can muster. "You don't have to stay, but you can."

"Okay," Castorice says warily. She looks like he wants to trust Mydei but isn't sure if she can. That's fair. They're strangers. Mydei had taken a long time to learn to trust again too. He'd fought tooth and nail before even considering joining the rest of the Chrysos Heirs. Phainon was the one who convinced him, pinning him down and winning their first fight only because Mydei had been malnourished and unrested. He'd held Mydei's wrists to his chest, blood dripping from a cut on his forehead into Mydei's face, and he'd had to say it over and over. *We're not going to hurt you, can't you see that? I could kill you right now, but I'm not? Why do you think that is? Why, Mydeimos?*

That was before either of them had grown into their powers. Titans, it feels like so long ago now.

"Okay," Mydei repeats, standing up. He offers a hand, but Castorice doesn't take it, pushing herself up on unsteady legs. She wobbles, drugged and sore and exhausted, and Mydei fights the urge to catch her or to offer help.

She stumbles into the wall, knees failing her, and this time Mydei does have to catch her before she can crash to the ground again. She's small and narrow and too thin in Mydei's arms, and for a moment she just goes still, staring up with these wide, bloodshot eyes. And then she struggles, fighting to get away and crying, "Don't, don't, *don't,"* over and over again, shaking, curling in on herself on the floor, and Mydei feels sick watching her. They all come beaten and bruised before they heal, but *this*—

"Castorice," Mydei says. Again, firmer, hearing the blood in his ears, *"Castorice."* He crouches. "You didn't hurt me. Look. *Look.* I'm okay. You need to—"

The door creaks open. "We need to go," Phainon says. "Right now. The Cleaners are coming."

"Shit," Mydei says. "Shit, *shit."*

"Are you immune?" Phainon asks, glancing at Castorice, this look in his eyes. He's urgent, but he isn't afraid. He trusts Mydei wholeheartedly the same way Mydei trusts him. Mydei nods once. "Then grab her and let's go."

"Shit," Mydei says again. He crouches, willing his heart to calm down long enough for him to figure this out. Castorice has gone quiet, but Mydei knows she can't walk by herself, as drugged as she is. She's just curled up, making herself so small, as far from Mydei as she can get. "Castorice," he says, a little softer. Level, comforting, safe. None of these things come naturally, but he can't flip out on her right now. "You haven't hurt me, okay? You won't." She doesn't respond, just shakes her head, shrinking away when Mydei tries to approach. "I need to help you," Mydei tells her. Cipher and Aglaea have joined Phainon in the doorway. Urgent, all of them. Again, "You're not going to hurt me."

Mydei reaches out. "No," Castorice protests weakly. Mydei hesitates, gritting his teeth, but he doesn’t even have a moment to think before Cipher

is putting a hand on his shoulder and brushing past him, pulling something from the inside of her cloak.

“Don’t take it personal, princess,” she says, ignoring the way Castorice shrinks back to press something into her neck, careful not to touch her. A sedative. Castorice barely mutters a few more weak protests before her energy slips away from her and she goes limp.

“Cipher,” Phainon says, voice low.

“It needed to happen, Deliverer, unless you were planning on letting her scream and cry and alert every Cleaner within a mile,” she says, pulling the syringe free and backing away. She turns to Mydei. “All yours. Let’s go.”

“We’re not *kidnappers,”* Phainon starts. Aglaea is the one who hushes them before they can continue arguing, still out of it.

“They see us,” she says, and her voice is frighteningly clear, slightly accented, though her eyes are still crazed and clouded. “I hear… ‘Chrysos,’ they’re saying. ‘Maiden of war.’”

Strange and cryptic, unsettling. Aglaea always reacts strangely when drugged. Her senses are already far different from anyone else’s, alter them on top of that and you get this.

Mydei quits hesitating and hauls the unconscious Castorice onto his back, pulling her arms around his neck, grabbing her under the thighs. She’s completely limp, light as a feather, breathing shallow against the back of his neck. She’s barely even warm, Titans above. Mydei gets her off the ground with ease.

Phainon wraps an arm around the delirious Aglaea to support her, and the five of them head out of the shipping container, slipping into its shadows to regroup. A quick scan of the area reveals nothing. Mydei turns to Aglaea. "How much time do we have?"

"They're watching," she says. “I feel it. They see… ‘Goldweaver,’ ‘Maiden of War.’ One minute. No, less. Seconds. They’re close, closer now.” She

isn’t walking well, and her eyes squint, mouth pressing into a hard line. What does the world look like to her? What does it feel like? Her threads can spread for miles, passing sound and sensation to her, but right now she’s so high nothing must make sense to her. Phainon just picks her up and slings her over his shoulder like a sack of potatoes, easy like she weighs nothing at all. He can lift a car one handed, since his strength manifested.

"Okaaay," Cipher says. "Move out, team. Quickly, yeah? I’d like to bask in victory tonight.”

Castorice still doesn’t stir. It barely feels like she’s breathing. There are too many drugs in her system. They need to get her to Hyacine, fast.

The ground is some odd combination of dirt, sand, and gravel, and it crunches with every step. "Thirty seconds,” Aglaea says, jostling with every step Phainon takes. Her arms dangle downward, fingers outstretched, tangled in faintly glowing gold threads. “They’re close now, everywhere, all sides. ‘Servant of Death, must—’”

"All sides?" Cipher hisses.

"I think," Aglaea continues, "they see us. They’re looking me in the eyes." Nevermind that her eyes are directed toward nothing but Phainon’s ass.

A breath passes. They’re all dead silent. Gravel crunches, and then there's a shout from behind. "Run," Cipher says, voice low, tail puffing up, and they do. All hell breaks loose. Mydei does his best to hold Castorice as stable as he can as he runs for his life. It's dark and he can hardly see where he's putting his feet, but he doesn't slow down. Phainon runs at his side, keeping pace. They exchange a glance, a grin as the adrenaline starts to kick in.

"Help us out, Aglaea," Phainon pants. Footfalls behind them, more shouting, metal creaking. The shipping yard is like a labyrinth; the Cleaners aren’t looking in the right places.

"It's dark," Aglaea murmurs. Castorice starts to slip, so Mydei adjusts his grip under her legs, tangling in the bunched fabric of her dress. "There are rocks. So many rocks. They’re looking at me."

"Very helpful," Phainon laughs. “What else?”

"Give her to me," Cipher says. "I'll get her to Tribbie." They're close to the cars, or that wouldn't work. Cipher's range is pretty short alone, half that with someone else. She can go maybe 50 meters per jump with Aglaea. Still, it's faster than running. Phainon practically tosses Aglaea to her, and then she's gone.

"I've got your back," Phainon tells him with a grin, barely even panting, pulling out his handgun. Anaxa and Tribbie's cars aren't parked in the same spot. They'll part ways here. Phainon won't stall too much, but he'll buy them a little time. “Let’s see who can get out of here faster, yeah?” The glimmer in his eye, the promise. Every mission Mydei has even been on, Phainon has had his back. There’s no one else he would trust it to.

He hoists Castorice a little higher and tries to catch his breath. "You’re on, Deliverer.” He can see light. A pair of figures break out from between a few shipping containers.

Phainon grins. "See you on the other side," he laughs. A gunshot. Mydei's ears ring. They split off in opposite directions, Phainon toward the Cleaners, Mydei toward Anaxa’s car. He can see it, a few hundred meters away. Phainon will get to Tribbie safely. He always does. Another gunshot. Mydei kind of wants to laugh. He’s fucked up on adrenaline.

“I’ve got you,” he says under his breath, more to himself than the unconscious Castorice. His muscles are burning. She’s starting to slip again. Ten more steps, the backseat door to the car rolls open. Another gunshot, farther away. They’re after Phainon, as planned. Mydei practically throws himself and Castorice inside, awkwardly landing face-first as the door closes behind him. Anaxa starts driving before Mydei can even sit up.

Wincing, Mydei eases Castorice off his back and upright, leaning her against the car door and buckling her in. Her eyes stay shut. She keeps breathing. More gunshots in the background. Mydei's heart does nothing to calm itself, still thundering in his ears as he does his own seatbelt. The ride is a far cry from smooth.

"I’m in touch with Tribios," Anaxa calls. "She has the rest of the team. They're being tailed."

Mydei lets out a breath. "Do what you need to," he says, and Anaxa pulls off onto a side road.

"Keep an eye on the back," Anaxa instructs. Mydei turns in his seat, freeing his handgun from his waistband. He keeps an eye out on Anaxa’s blind side as well, squinting in the dark. "That kid buckled in good?"

A glance at Castorice, still sleeping. "Yeah," Mydei confirms. Gunshots. Three of them. The car vibrates under Mydei's feet.

"I see them," Anaxa says, the engine revving as he speeds up. The car wrenches into a turn, Mydei grabbing onto the back of the seat. Anaxa says something to Tribbie through his in-ear, then addresses Mydei, "We're good behind?"

"All clear," Mydei says.

"All clear," Anaxa repeats to Tribbie. "Send her over."

More gunfire. Cipher blinks into the passenger's seat of the car. "Shit," she says, “it isn’t easy teleporting into a moving vehicle, you know. How fast are you going? A hundred fifty? You guys are lucky I’m as fleet-footed as I am."

Anaxa checks the speedometer. "Ninety-three," he answers drily. "All you, kid."

"There are three cars," Cipher says in a rush, "get one away from Tribbie, and then get me close. You'll have to be fast."

"One's already following us," Mydei says. There's someone leaning out the window, a rifle aimed in their direction. "They’ve got a gun." Anaxa slows down just a little, letting them catch up.

Cipher turns to look, tongue between her teeth, eyes narrow. "A little closer," she says, ears perking atop her head. Two gunshots. One hits the

car, clanging against metal. "Closer…" There's a click as Cipher turns the safety off her gun. "Perfect. Don't get too far." And then she's gone. Four more shots. The car behind them swerves and drives into a ditch. Cipher blinks back into the car, sighing for show, tail swishing. "One shot left," she says, waving a hand at Mydei. "Help a cat out, would you?" Mydei passes his gun over, watches her fingers curl tight over it, nails painted black, knuckles white. She's good at pretending, but she's scared too.

Anaxa steps on the gas to catch up to Tribbie. The other two cars won't leave her alone, shots popping in the space between them.

"Just get me close," Cipher says, her eyes crazed. "We can't lead them away. Just... get me close, and I'll take care of everything."

"Cipher," Anaxa says, voice low.

"I've done this before," she says, bending over the back of his seat to give Mydei another upside-down smile. There's blood on her cheek. Red, not her own. "I'm a professional."

"Go for the left one," Anaxa says, gaining on the two Cleaner cars. "And do *try* to keep the mess out of the road."

"Got it, Prof," Cipher says. One more smile. "Stay close."

"Got it."

"See y'all in a minute."

Cipher teleports away. Mydei's stomach twists up into knots. He can't see much of anything. He can only hear the gunshots and the crash and feel the way Anaxa swerves hard enough to slam him into the door.

She's supposed to teleport before the crash happens. She takes control of one car and crashes it into the second, but she gets out at the last second so she doesn't get hurt. That's what's supposed to happen. But Mydei heard the crash and she isn't here and when he squints out the window, he can see the

two cars, collided and crushed like tin cans, sparking with flame and smoke, but he can’t see her.

"Shit," he says, stomach dropping. "Shit. Where is she?”

The tires scream as Anaxa brakes, wrenching the car into a u-turn. "She's fine," he says. "Relax. She missed, that's it. She couldn't make it into the car. Keep an eye out for her."

So he keeps an eye out as they circle back to the wreckage of the Cleaner cars. No more gunshots follow. Tribbie’s car has made it out, but where’s *Cipher?*

They drive and drive, Mydei squinting in the dark until he can see a spark of light. Cipher flags them down with a small flare, burning blue in the night. "There," Mydei says. His voice is rough. "To the right." Anaxa slows to a stop, and they pick Cipher back up. She's pale and covered in red blood and sweat, but she’s grinning as she stomps out the flare and climbs into the car.

"My in-ear broke," she says, buckling in. She passes Mydei's gun back with shaking hands, the proof that she’s not half as unruffled as she seems. "How's Tribbie's car?"

"Good," Anaxa says. "It was just those three cars following. She’s got Phainon and that woman and they’re heading home."

"Thank the Titans," Cipher sighs, splaying in her seat. For a long while, they all just breathe. Anaxa drives them home.

"How's the kid?” he asks. "Still knocked out?"

Mydei looks over. Castorice's mouth is slack, eyes shut. She's still thin and dirty and drugged, blood on her clothes, but her chest rises and falls softly. "Yeah," Mydei confirms.

"Oh, she’s gonna hate me when she wakes up," Cipher says, turning awkwardly again. Her breath has calmed, expression smoothed out as she

studies Castorice. One of her ears flicks, blood caught in her fur. “What a princess,” she murmurs, propping her chin on her arms. "What was her name? She told you, didn’t she? Before I had to play villain?”

Castorice's head falls against the window, neck uncomfortably bent. It's a wonder she didn't wake up through all the gunfire and swerving. It must’ve been a strong sedative. The sound of her cries echoes in Mydei’s head, over and over.

"Castorice," he says. "Her name is Castorice."

△

They get home without issue. Tribbie's group gets back first; Aglaea is already passed out in bed, and Phainon waits for them in the living room. Cipher retreats to bathe. Castorice doesn't wake. Mydei has to carry her up. There’s nowhere for her to stay, so Mydei puts her in his own bed for the night. He'll sleep on the couch, and they'll figure out something more permanent in the morning. Assuming Castorice wants to stay with them at all.

She's still all dirty. Mydei just washed his sheets. He leaves a glass of water on the nightstand and steals one of the pillows.

Phainon is on the couch when he comes back out. He's changed his clothes and washed off the blood, but Mydei doesn't think he showered. His hair isn’t wet. It's too late for that. He's too tired. Once the adrenaline runs out, they all crash, left with nothing but this bone-deep exhaustion from a job well done. Mydei sits down next to him. Silently, Phainon tips into his shoulder.

"How was that?" he asks. "Pretty good job, huh?”

"We all almost died,” Mydei says. All it earns him is a hum. He looks at Phainon. His closed eyes, his smushed cheek. He’s warm now, injured hand freshly bandaged in his lap. “How’s your hand?”

“Fine,” Phainon answers. His eyes are still closed. Maybe he’s falling asleep. He’s quiet for a little while. “I get why she’s so afraid of touching people,” he adds after a while. “It might’ve been the worst pain of my life.”

“And yet you were so insistent on saving her,” Mydei murmurs. He leans his cheek against Phainon’s hair. Their thighs press. One of Phainon’s ankles curls around his.

“We’re all strays, Mydeimos,” he says, echoing his words from before. A pause, a breath. The lights flicker, and he shifts further against Mydei’s side. Careful, Mydei slips an arm around his back. “She reminded me of you, a little bit.”

Mydei scoffs. “I didn’t cry and curl up like that.”

“No,” Phainon chuckles. His good hand crawls over their thighs, pinky hooking Mydei’s until he turns his hand up and their fingers slot together. Wound together like this, it’s hard to tell whose warmth is whose. They need to talk, but this is good enough, isn’t it? *We’re okay,* it says. *Nothing needs to change.* “You only knew how to hurt people, but… you didn’t *want* to. I think she’s like that too.”

“Those are some big assumptions to make about someone you’ve only just met.”

Phainon hums softly, tips his face up to look at Mydei, close enough to share breath, eyes clear blue and warmer than they ought to be. “Maybe.” A pause, their eyes on each other. “I’m glad you could be there.”

“I barely did anything.”

“No,” Phainon says, and skims his injured fingers along Mydei’s jaw. He leans in for a kiss, just once, just softly. His mouth is warmer than the rest of him. He tastes like mint, and his eyes take a while to open after he pulls away. "You did plenty."

Mydei kisses him again, just a press of lips. He feels Phainon’s exhale against him, sucks softly on his bottom lip. They’re both too exhausted for

anything more than this. He pulls back, and Phainon settles back against him, squeezing their joined hands.

They're quiet for a little while. This is familiar. They do this a lot, after every mission. Sometimes Aglaea and Cipher will join them too, and the four of them will sit and talk until they're too tired for even that. So Mydei always feels like family, even if he doesn’t get to go on the missions with them.

"I'm glad we got Aglaea back,” Phainon murmurs.

"Me too."

Phainon sighs softly. “Do you think Castorice will want to stay?” he asks.

"Depends." It isn’t much of an answer, but Mydei doesn’t know. She’d been so scared, and then Cipher had to hit her with a tranquilizer. She’ll wake up safe and unharmed, but Mydei can’t imagine this building a good foundation for trust. "We’ll find out in the morning, I guess.”

“In the morning,” Phainon repeats. He’s a soft creature at night. Mydei is too. Too tired to fight him, to argue, to bicker. There’s just this. Sturdy weight and body heat. The bloody smell of him. “Were you going to sleep out here?”

“Yeah,” Mydei whispers.

“Come to my room,” Phainon says. “It’s a squeeze, but I don’t mind.” His bed is only a twin. They’ve packed into it together before, but Mydei doesn’t like to be presumptuous. Not when neither of them is quite sure what exactly this is.

“Alright,” Mydei says. He can’t think of a reason to protest. Phainon is warm. He’s so tired. Together, they stand and drag their feet to Phainon’s room. When they crawl under the covers, side by side, Mydei is out like a light.

In the morning, Castorice is gone.

△

Mydei's back in the dungeon. He goes on three more missions within the next six months while everyone else probably goes on a dozen or more. Seven more, within the year. More than one every other month. It might be the best ratio he’s ever had, which is saying something. The Cleaners have been busy, and he’s needed more and more. He feels more productive, more useful, more like part of the team, even if he still has to stay back more often than not.

That’s what happens today. Another mission where Mydei isn’t needed. Aglaea is the brains, Phainon the brawn, Cipher the shadows. It's fine. He could have come in the getaway car if he wanted, but he hates that more than this. Instead, he cleans up their flat a little, cooks himself dinner, and curls up on the couch to watch a movie. Maybe he should look into adopting a pet. Maybe a dog so he has a reason to go outside. Phainon would probably try to talk him into getting a cat instead. Cipher might too. He doesn’t think Aglaea would care either way.

A cat, then. A cat would probably be best, just so Phainon is happy. Cipher too.

Mydei is home alone watching a movie in his shared four-bedroom flat when there's a knock on the door. A delivery, maybe. Cipher is known to order more things than she needs and hoard them in her room. He isn’t sure, so he pauses the movie and gets up. He opens the door.

There's a girl in the hallway, gloved hands clasped in front of her, gaze climbing the door frame before it lands on Mydei. Her hair is long enough to reach her knees, soft pink, neatly combed, and styled into twin ponytails. The sweater she wears covers her practically up to the jaw. "Hello."

"Hi," Mydei says. "It's been a while."

"There are people after me," Castorice says, awkwardly smiling. She's a far cry from the distressed, drugged-up creature she'd been a year ago. "I don't have many options, but… turn me away, if it’s a bother."

Mydei looks at her a little longer. The way her gaze stubbornly avoids his. The way her fingers are tangled tight in front of her. The way there isn't a single inch of exposed skin below her head. It's the middle of summer.

"Come in," Mydei tells her, backing out of the doorway. "I'm watching a movie. I can restart it, if you want."

△

Castorice has this way of sitting quietly, body as small as possible. They sit next to each other on the couch, but it doesn't really feel like it, with how much space she gives Mydei. She's still wearing her gloves and her turtleneck and long pants and socks. Mydei is in shorts and a tank top. Barefoot. The movie he'd been watching plays on in the silence. Castorice hasn't said a word.

"You can take the gloves off," Mydei says. They keep the flat kind of warm in the summer to save on the energy bill. Cold in the winter too. "Roll up your sleeves or whatever; I know it's hot as hell in here."

"Thank you," Castorice says, and does no such thing. Mydei watches her from the corner of his eye. The way she sits small and stiff. She's only pretending to watch the movie, same as he is. The smallest sound or movement makes her curl in on herself. Mydei sucks in a breath.

"I'm the only one home tonight," he says. "The others are out on a mission and probably won't be back until way later." Castorice doesn't look at him. Mydei plays with his own fingers and adds, because his gut is twisting with Titans know what, "You're not at risk of hurting anyone."

Castorice's breath stills before she picks it back up. She doesn't display any other reaction. After a long moment, quietly, carefully, she peels her gloves off one by one. She sets them on her knees and folds her bare, slender hands in her lap like she doesn't know what to do with them. Mydei said that to make her comfortable. Somehow, she seems even less so.

"Castorice"

She looks at him and looks horribly out of place, like she doesn't think she belongs here, or anywhere at all, and Mydei doesn’t have a weakness for strays, not the way the rest of them do, but he knows what that feels like. To be afraid of the world, but mostly your own hands. To not have a soul to trust on the entire planet.

“I don’t know if I ever got your name,” she says softly. “Or I must’ve forgotten, what with…” She doesn’t mention the drugging, or the tranquilizer, or the way she left in the morning. Who knows how much of it she remembers, regardless.

“Mydei,” he tells her. “How much do you remember?”

The way she shrunk back like she does now. The way she tried so hard to keep them from touching her, pleading and begging them not to. The way they did anyway, and then knocked her out. She might have woken up safe and sound, but she must be desperate to come back here.

Castorice tucks her hands between her thighs like she wants to hide all her bare skin. She’s so good at shrinking she could probably disappear if she tried. “Enough,” she answers.

“Then you know that you can’t hurt me,” Mydei tells her. “I carried you out of there, and I’m just fine. You can relax.”

Castorice hesitates. "I know,” she agrees.

Something about her body language, the set of her expression. "You think it was a fluke,” Mydei notes. He cocks his head when she doesn’t reply. "You were drugged as hell, do you remember that part?”

"Why aren't you on the mission with the rest of your group?" Castorice asks. It feels random. It feels like a diversion.

Mydei waves her off. "I'm not useful the way the rest of them are," he says. "Do you remember?"

"What do you mean you're not useful? You're immune to things; isn't that one of the best powers you could have for your... job?"'

Job. That's almost funny. "Castorice."

Castorice takes a breath. "Yes," she says. "I remember."

The movie drones on. Neither of them is pretending to watch it anymore. Mydei's already seen this part anyway. He studies her. "Why are you here," he asks.

Castorice's lips part. She wets them, avoiding eye contact. Her voice is soft and small when she speaks. "I had nowhere else to go."

"You said people are after you."

"Yes."

"Is it the Cleaners?" They're after all of them. If you bleed gold, if you have a power, the Cleaners want you gone, and the cops won't bother to do anything about it.

Castorice doesn't answer, but the way she tenses up is as good as a yes. Mydei goes quiet, just thinking. A long moment passes. Finally, she speaks. "I've heard people say that touching me is the worst pain they've experienced in their life." She pauses, but Mydei doesn't interrupt her. Phainon said that too. "Skin to skin is like… It'll melt the skin off your hand if you touch me long enough. Even through clothes... You saw your friend's hand. That's why I—"

Phainon's fingers are still scarred faintly, a year later. "They want to use you as a weapon," Mydei realizes.

"Have been," Castorice corrects. A beat. "Or… A torture device. Not really a weapon."

"Why were you there, that day?"

"I was being sold off," Castorice says, "to someone else who wanted to..."

Mydei looks at her. Clothing covering her head to toe. Bare hands tangled in her lap. "Would you trust me for a second?”

"I don't know you at all."

"But you came here," Mydei says, pausing the TV. The silence between them rings without the movie as background noise. "You're scared and you have nowhere to go. You probably can't trust a single person on this earth, but you came here, and that has to count for something." Silence. Castorice only looks at him. Slowly, Mydei holds a hand out, palm up, fingers open. She eyes it warily. "Take my hand."

"I think it's best if I don't."

"I won't make you," Mydei tells her. "But you won’t hurt me if you do, and it might be nice to know that when you’re not drugged to hell.”

She frowns. A moment passes, and Mydei starts to withdraw his hand.

"Wait." Castorice wets her lips. Slowly, she reaches out, pausing close, but not enough to touch. She looks like she regrets it as soon as she does. Mydei meets her eyes and counts to six. He takes Castorice's hand in his.

Instantly, she flinches, shivers, pulls her hand free, tucking it with the other between her thighs. She looks shaken, and Mydei opens his palms. Smooth, pale, skin. A tiny scar from where he’d cut himself while cooking, but no burns, no blood. "Doesn't hurt a bit," he says. Castorice stares at his hand for a while longer, and then she clears her throat.

"Your... organization," she says, "do you have a leader?"

Mydei drops his hands into his lap, settling more comfortably on the couch. "Kind of?" he tries. They consider Aglaea their leader, but she doesn’t call herself that. "We're really just a group of dumbasses.”

"And yet…" Castorice pauses. "You were involved in... whatever that was, that night. And your friends are out on a 'mission.'"

"Dumbasses who do stuff to make ends meet," Mydei amends.

"Stuff," Castorice repeats.

"Dangerous and illegal stuff," Mydei offers. "Vigilante shit. We fight the Cleaners. I'm sure you've seen how effective the police are around here." Quietly, Castorice nods. She would know better than anyone. Who knows how long she'd been trafficked and used as a weapon.

"Hey," he says instead, "I don't know what you were looking for when you came here, but we take people in all the time. You can stay, if you want. You could have stayed back then."

Castorice thinks about this for a long time, staring into her lap. "You'd be surprised," she says, "by how many times I've heard that."

"Ah." Mydei gets that too. That day in the dirt, Phainon pinning him down and letting him go, he hadn’t understood what they wanted from him either. He hadn’t believed he could trust them. So he ran, and the next time he saw them, he lost the fight and was offered a place to stay. He stands up and stretches. “Think on it for a bit, then. I’ll give you money for a hotel and Aglaea’s number. Come back if you want, or don’t.”

Castorice hesitates. “...Aglaea?”

"Our leader, kind of. You asked about her."

Castorice is silent. She plays with her gloves in her lap and then pulls them back on. "Okay," she says after a moment. Again, quieter, "Okay."

Mydei finds his wallet. There's two hundred dollars in it. Enough for a hotel and whatever else Castorice might need. Mydei doesn't know how she's been living up until now. He takes all of the money and drops it in her lap. She barely even looks at it before she says, "That's too much."

Two hundred dollars. Too much for a cheap hotel and a gas station meal, sure. "It's expensive around here," Mydei lies. She looks at him for a long moment before she splits the cash in half and sets the extra on the coffee table. Quietly, she stands, and then she leaves like that. Like the wind.

Dressed head to toe in the middle of summer, a hundred dollars in her pocket.

△

Phainon, Cipher, and Aglaea come home late. They bring cuts and bruises with them, but they say the mission went about as well as it could have. They're still alive, and that's enough.

Phainon comes to Mydei with a bruise under his shoulder blade. He says he'd been hit with a pipe, and though he'd heard it coming, he wasn't fast enough to dodge. His knuckles are busted too. He punched a wall instead of a person and used a little too much force. His strength has been presented for years now, but he still forgets it sometimes.

He peels off his shirt in the bathroom for Mydei to put ointment on his back, the bruise already dark and discolored.

“You’re too reckless,” Mydei tells him. “Why didn’t you go to Hyacine?”

“It’s not *that* bad,” Phainon protests, but he winces as Mydei’s fingers skim the injury to rub the ointment in. “I’m pretty sturdy.”

Mydei snorts and steps back, twisting the cap back onto the tube of ointment. “Sure,” he says, and Phainon turns around so they’re face to face, packed tight into this tiny bathroom. He’s smiling a little. There’s always this gnawing feeling in the back of his mind that never eases until he sees Phainon safe after a job.

“I am!” Phainon insists, blue eyed and messy haired and bare chested. Mydei takes his injured hand, dried and scabbed now, and pulls it to the sink to wash. “You’ve tested it yourself.”

“You’ve got fucking super strength and somehow you still lose to me sometimes,” Mydei chuckles. He’s gentle as he rubs away the crusted gold blood under the faucet, but Phainon still hisses through his teeth. “So sturdy,” he teases. Phainon flicks a bit of water at him.

“Shut up, that hand’s been hurting for hours.”

“Maybe don’t punch walls, then.” The faucet squeaks as Mydei shuts it off. He towel dries Phainon’s hand and feels along his bones to make sure they’re all in place, gaze tipped down between them.

“Nothing’s broken,” Phainon says softly. His breath ruffles Mydei’s hair. His hand flexes demonstratively in Mydei’s. “Just sore.”

So Mydei rubs ointment into his knuckles too and wraps his hand in white bandages. It’s the same hand with the shiny scar tissue from Castorice. Phainon is always hurting his hands. They’re rough with callouses and crooked from broken fingers not set correctly. Sometimes his body can’t keep up with how strong he is.

“Try not to use this, for a while,” Mydei says, securing the edge of the bandage. “Hyacine will kick your ass if you make it worse.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Phainon murmurs. The fingers of his good hand skim Mydei’s waist. They look at each other. His smile is soft, beckoning. “Sorry.”

“Stop getting hurt, and you won’t have to apologize,” Mydei shoots back. But he steps closer, he always does. Phainon lets him cage him in against the counter, tips their mouths together first. He tastes a bit like blood. Mydei kisses him long and slow, draws back only enough to lean their foreheads together.

“You should pester Aglaea about coming on more missions,” Phainon whispers. He knows best how restless Mydei gets. He’s been going on more and more missions lately, but it still isn’t enough. He still can’t fight that useless feeling, but he never protests, never asks to be made part of the plan. It really would be as easy as that.

“I know,” he says. Phainon kisses his cheek this time, cupping the back of his neck. There’s the scratch of bandages against skin. He uses his hurt hand for this. “Phainon.”

“I want you by my side,” Phainon murmurs, kissing a little higher up his cheekbone. “I’ll ask for you, if you want.”

“Don’t fight my battles for me.”

“Alright,” Phainon says softly. He pulls back just a bit. “Sleep in my bed tonight?”

“Yeah,” Mydei says. “Yeah, I’ll come.” So they sleep in the same bed that night. Packed just a bit too tight. It’s too warm under the blankets, and Phainon drools on his shoulder. They still don’t talk about it. They do this and they kiss but they don’t talk about it, but titans be damned if Mydei isn’t home.

In the morning, Castorice doesn't come. They wake up late and have breakfast. Mydei waits until noon before he goes grocery shopping, just in case. He drags Cipher with him, so she won't be alone. Cipher often spirals if she's left alone after a job. Aglaea usually handles it, but Mydei doesn’t mind bringing her today. The company is nice. He just has to keep an eye out to make sure she doesn’t steal anything.

She complains a bit as they pick out fruit. He won’t let her get six different flavors of ice cream. When he catches her about to slip away, probably to steal, he grabs her by the hood the way one might scruff a housecat. She doesn’t take kindly to this, but he doesn’t particularly care.

His thoughts turn back to Castorice. Over and over, he sees the look in her eyes. It isn't his business. It shouldn't matter to him. He wishes he could forget like he did a year ago, but he can't. Not this time. Phainon’s soft spot for strays must be rubbing off on him.

They go home. Phainon is on lunch duty. None of them are in the mood to go out again today. Mydei sits with Cipher and Aglaea on the couch as they wait for Phainon to concoct something hopefully edible from the ingredients Mydei bought. They watch something on the TV. There's no knock on the door throughout the rest of the day. By the time they go to bed, there's no sign of Castorice coming back. No sign she was ever here at all.

Mydei wonders where she went, hopes she's okay. He sleeps alone that night. They all do. The night is way too hot to spend in someone else’s arms. Castorice is probably dressed head to toe and then some. She’s probably melting, wherever she is. It’s none of his business.

△

Aglaea calls while he’s at the gym, struggling through his second set of lat pulldowns. He lets the bar go and answers the phone, making eye contact with himself in the mirror. The line is quiet for a bit before she speaks. On Mydei’s end, there must be too loud music and the clang of weights. "Someone contacted me earlier," Aglaea says. Mydei sits up. "She wouldn't give me any information about herself but she said she needed help."

"Okay," Mydei says, reaching for his water bottle.

"Mydeimos," Aglaea says firmly. "She mentioned you. She tipped us about a Cleaner hideout and then she mentioned you."

"She…” Castorice. An odd feeling stirs in Mydei’s chest.

Aglaea continues, “She said you told her to come to me, but she won't tell me anything about herself. I find this curious, and I’d like to know what you do.”

It's been a week since Castorice came. Long enough that the money he gave her must've run out. So where will she be? How is she surviving? "She wouldn’t be lying if she tipped you off,” Mydei says. A glance at the other gym-goers around him. None appear to be listening, but he still stands and makes quick work of wiping his bench down before he slips away. “She’s running from the Cleaners. It’s that girl from when you got kidnapped and left in the shipping yard. Can you trace the call?”

"That man is already working on it," Aglaea says, that hint of disdain in her voice only present when she speaks of Anaxa. “Are you certain it’s her? She ran as soon as she recovered, did she not? Why has she returned?”

“Yes, it’s her,” Mydei confirms. “She came back to the flat a week ago but she didn’t want to stay. I gave her some cash and she left again. As for why she’s back… I don’t know. She doesn’t have anywhere to go, she said it herself.”

A less than amused hum on the other side of the line. A hot breeze whips Mydei’s hair into his face as he stands outside, squinting in the sun. “She came last week,” Aglaea says dryly. “A highly dangerous ability-user, and you didn’t think to tell anyone?”

“She’s a stray, just like the rest of us,” Mydei says. His mouth is dry. He’s just as bad as Phainon. Why does he care so much? Why does it matter? He listens to Aglaea’s inhale. “We can trust her.”

There’s a long, long pause. “Very well,” Aglaea says. “I’m trusting *you*, Mydeimos. If you’re certain, we’ll send a team to find and secure her safety while I figure out what to do with the Cleaners.”

"Wait," Mydei says, "wait. You can't just send a whole bunch of people. She’s terrified, she’ll never come with us.”

“She knows you, at least,” Aglaea muses. “Very well, then. Take Cipher.”

“Cipher was the one who drugged her last time,” Mydei points out.

A sigh. “Phainon, then. I trust you won’t get distracted on the job?”

“What do you take us for?”

“A bunch of fools,” Aglaea mutters. “Keep him under control, and try not to create a scene when you find the girl. That last thing we need is the Cleaners all up in our business.”

“Castorice,” Mydei tells her. “Her name is Castorice.”

△

Phainon looks far too excited to come with him. They’re dressed casually instead of in their gear in an attempt to avoid attention, but Phainon has lost

the memo, dressed in four different, non coordinating bright colors. Aglaea makes him change, and he comes back out in a simple blue t-shirt and a pair of white joggers. He’s got his hands tucked into his pockets and he looks quite fresh and clean, like a college student or the boy next door. Mydei tries not to look at him too long, and probably fails. He clears his throat and says, "Don't try to touch her again."

"I won't," Phainon says simply. He doesn't bring up how much it hurt when he touched Castorice the first time, or the scar tissue still on his hand, and Mydei is grateful. The place Anaxa traced the call to is a slightly dingy motel. He said Castorice didn't pick up when they tried to call her back, but Mydei wouldn't be surprised if she's still around here. When they step inside, the air smells kind of musty. There are water stains on the ceiling. Mydei wonders if this is where that hundred dollars went.

There's a tired looking woman at the front desk, deep dark circles under her eyes when she looks up. "Hi," Phainon says, smiling his most charming smile—one he's probably spent hours perfecting in the mirror—while Mydei inspects the place. She perks up a bit, but that’s just the Phainon Effect. "We're looking for someone. She’s about as tall as my shoulder, give or take, dresses in turtlenecks and gloves all the time?"

She blinks at him, then spares a glance at Mydei, who probably looks like some kind of thug with his severe expression and tattooed body. Mydei is certain she's going to tell them she can't share that kind of information, but she just nods slowly and says, "You're probably looking for the girl in room eight." And that's... Really terrible security, but Mydei doesn't say anything. Phainon smiles a little wider and thanks her.

“And my charm strikes again,” Phainon says, dumb and triumphant as they head down the hall to room eight. They bump shoulders and Mydei gives him a withering look before they come to a stop in front of the door. Phainon knocks twice. They wait for a moment, but there isn't an answer.

Mydei steps forward on the worn, stained carpet in the hallway. He leans in and clears his throat. "Miss Castorice—"

A clatter from inside. "Shit,” Phainon says, “she’s running.”

"What?"

"Probably out the window," Phainon continues, reaching for the door handle. “If only Aglaea were with us, she could hear, but—”

Why is she running? He hasn’t even had a chance to speak and they’ve already messed this up. If she gets away, God knows if they’ll ever find her again. Maybe the Cleaners will get to her and use her as a weapon again, and they can’t afford that. Aglaea is already going to kill them for making a mess for her to cover up. “Nevermind that,” he interrupts Phainon. “Just get the door, fuck.”

After a couple of measured motions—he isn’t trying to tear the door off its hinges, after all—Phainon breaks the lock. "Got it," he says, swinging the door open. Inside is a ratty upholstery armchair, something that could possibly pass for a bed, and on the far wall, an open window. The drop isn't too big for them to climb out. "Left," he breathes. “Right is just dead ends.

So they go left, side by side, Phainon maybe a little bit faster because of the super strength. They must be faster than Castorice, because after a while they can hear her footsteps well enough to follow her. She takes alleyways rather than the main street, so no one gets in their way. "We're gaining," Mydei pants, and sure enough, he catches a flash of light pink hair.

"Let's split," Phainon calls. He takes left, Mydei right. They're all slowing down a bit, out of breath, but Mydei runs until he stumbles his way into a dead end. He must've made a wrong turn at some point. Castorice too, because she's here when she shouldn't be, climbing the dirty stone wall from the other side. She's panting, her arms shaking as she hoists herself up, getting her foot on the ledge, not seeing him yet.

"Castorice," Mydei says, lungs straining, and her eyes go wide and terrified as her head snaps up to look at him. And then she slips. Her foot doesn't make it, and she tumbles off the wall, hitting her head at the bottom and collapsing in a heap. "Holy shit," Mydei gasps, going to her. A small groan answers him.

"Don't—" Castorice croaks. "Don't come closer."

"It's me," Mydei says, stopping in his tracks. "Mydei. You're safe, I swear you're safe." Slowly, Castorice sits up, lifting her head. Her hair is a mess, tangled and pooling around her, turtleneck ripped a bit at the shoulder seam. Her gaze looks a little hazy, probably from the fall.

"Mydei," she repeats, and then her eyes fall to Phainon, who jogs up next to him. She squints a bit, blinking hard like her eyes aren't cooperating with her. "You brought your friend with you." She rubs her face with her sleeve, reaching fingers to the back of her head to make sure there's no blood.

"We're not here to hurt you," Phainon offers, barely even out of breath. Castorice squints harder at him.

"You..." she can't seem to catch her breath. "Did I ever..." She blinks hard again, unsteady even though she's sitting. "Hurt... you?"

Mydei takes a step closer, another. Castorice's head dips to look at the ground. She mutters something too soft for Mydei to hear, and then she sways a bit. Mydei hits his knees on the way down, barely managing to catch her before she can fall again and hit her head again.

Phainon comes closer, lets out a long breath. "What just happened?" he asks. Mydei tries to guide Castorice to lean against the wall, but it's hard when her body is limp. Too warm through her out of season clothes. Her head knocks into his collarbone.

"She's..." He swallows thickly as he feels something warm and tacky at the base of her skull. Blood. Titans above. "She fell off the wall and hit her head, she must've..."

Castorice stirs, trying to pull away from Mydei's hold. She's too weak and confused to be successful, but Mydei lets her go once he's sure she won't fall over. "Castorice," he says. She just frowns at him, pupils blown wide. "I think you're concussed."

"Why are you here?" She asks him, words slurring a bit.

"To help," Mydei says. "I said I would help, remember?"

"Oh." Castorice blinks. "I need to go," she says, trying to stand up. “I thought you were the Cleaners.” She stumbles again. Mydei catches her, but this time she jerks out of his hold as quick as lightning. “Don’t—”

“You didn’t hurt me,” Mydei reminds her, but he takes a step back and lifts his open palms so she can see. One is slicked with her blood, bright gold, so he wipes it on his pants quickly. He bumps into Phainon behind him, whose fingers settle on his hips to steady him.

"We’re here to help," Phainon says, soft and soothing and level. He’s better at that than Mydei is. "You hit your head. I'm sorry if we scared you, but we're here to help." Castorice looks at him, kind of dazed. Belatedly, he adds, “I’m Phainon. A friend, I promise.”

"I don't know you at all," she says. “Why are you even here?”

“The Cleaners are after you,” Mydei reminds her. “We’re trying to offer you refuge, at least until they’re dealt with.”

“...Then why'd you chase me?"

"We knocked on your door nicely at first, you know," Phainon says, trying for lighthearted, for teasing. “You’re the one that ran, and we didn’t know if we’d be able to find you again if we didn’t chase you today.” Castorice frowns.

"You called Aglaea, remember?” Mydei adds. “You told her about the Cleaner’s hideout, and she wanted us to offer you a safe place to stay while we handle it. We’ve already let you go twice, remember? We’ll let you go again after you see a doctor if you really don’t want to stay. But… We’re all like you, with shitty pasts and trauma. You have a home with us, if you want it.”

Phainon smiles, hand settling more firmly on Mydei’s hip as he stands at his side. “Mydei’s a damn good cook, you know. And I’m… uh… A damn good friend? No hard feelings about last time. That was my bad.”

Castorice looks at them for a long moment, gaze still blown and muddy. Mydei's not sure how much of this she's even understanding, how badly she’s concussed. She’s bleeding at least. A handful of breaths pass. "I don't think I would have ran if I knew," she finally says, tongue thick. "Tell me next time, before you knock."

"Okay," Mydei breathes. His hands flex at his sides and he’s a bit unsure what to do with himself. Phainon squeezes his hip.

Castorice leans heavily into the wall. “My head hurts," she murmurs.

"We need to get you to a doctor," Mydei reminds her, glancing at Phainon. Phainon pulls out his phone to call Hyacine.

"No," Castorice says, "no."

"She's one of us" Mydei says, "we'll tell her not to touch you and she won't, and once you're better you can go or stay or do whatever you want, but I can't leave you on the street concussed and bleeding."

Castorice blinks again. Every time she does, she looks more and more confused. She touches the back of her head, stares at the blood that sticks to her fingers, glances at the stain on Mydei’s pants.

"It’s my fault," Mydei adds. "That's why I need to fix it."

Castorice makes a disgruntled sound and tries to stand up. Mydei reaches a hesitant hand to help her, but she supports herself on the wall and doesn’t take it. "I’m fine," she says, "I can walk."

"Okay," Mydei says, but he hovers close. He can't risk Castorice hitting her head again, but he can't very well force her to accept his help. Not when she’s so afraid of being touched. He swallows, throat dry. "We've got a car. It's close."

"Okay," Castorice says, "okay." She's a little off balance, but she's starting to gather her bearings. Mydei hopes that means the injury is mild. Phainon hovers next to Mydei while Mydei hovers next to Castorice. She won't look

at either of them, staring resolutely at the ground. On his opposite side, Phainon takes his hand, squeezes it. He’s grown too good at reading Mydei over the years, at knowing when he’s anxious even when he shouldn’t be. His hand is warm. Mydei squeezes back.

△

"You were right," Hyacine says, lowering the flashlight she'd been shining into Castorice's eyes. "She's concussed."

"That much is fairly obvious," Mydei points out. "Is she going to be okay?" Castorice shifts slightly, sitting on the padded exam table in Hyacine's office. She keeps her knees together and her hands folded in her lap, making herself small. She goes rigid every time Hyacine comes close, but she hasn't said anything, and Hyacine hasn't touched her once. Mydei and Phainon are mainly here as moral support, because Castorice looked so lost and uncomfortable when they brought her here.

"She'll be fine," Hyacine says, and then she turns to Castorice. "Just get a lot of rest, okay? You'll probably be tired and your head is going to hurt. I'll give you some painkillers—"

"No," Castorice says.

Hyacine's mouth closes. She glances at Mydei, Phainon—who’s doing a remarkable job at keeping quiet, sitting at Mydei’s side—and back at Castorice. "Okay," she says, kind of softly, understanding. "We've only got the over the counter stuff, if that helps, but no one's going to make you take it. If you change your mind, you can always come back here." Quietly, Castorice nods. "Don't be afraid to sleep a lot," Hyacine continues, "It won't make you fall into a coma, or whatever they say online. Sleep if you're tired and try to avoid bright lights and screens for a while. If something makes your head hurt, don't do it." Again, Castorice nods. Hyacine looks at her a little longer, smiling gently. "Where are you staying?" she asks.

Castorice just shrugs. Mydei plays with Phainon’s fingers. "She can stay with us," Phainon offers when he notices Mydei’s expression. Castorice turns to look at them. Phainon, their joined hands in Mydei’s lap.

"You live with three other people," Hyacine says, "where are you going to put her? She's concussed, you can't put her on the couch, and…" She purses her lips the way she always does when she's about to say something that might cause offense. "...Cipher isn't exactly the most peaceful roommate. Castorice needs peace and quiet and a real bed if she's going to recover."

"Mydei can just sleep with me," Phainon says easily. Mydei kicks his foot. Hyacine gives them a hesitant expression. Castorice just looks lost and helpless.

"Would you be alright staying here tonight?" Hyacine asks Castorice, choosing to ignore them. She points at a door behind herself. "There's a room with a bed and stuff through there. We can find something more permanent for you in the morning. Does that work for you?"

Castorice is quiet for a moment. "You'll let me stay?"

"Of course," Hyacine tells her. Slowly, Castorice nods. Hyacine smiles at her. "Get some rest. I've got some clothes you can change into and you can wash up in the bathroom if you want." She hesitates a bit, looking at Castorice, the way she's dressed from head to toe. The only skin exposed below her neck is a tiny sliver where her shirt ripped at the shoulder seam. "Would you prefer something with long sleeves?"

Castorice nods tightly. "If you have it."

"I'll find something, and then we'll leave you to rest," Hyacine says. She turns to Mydei and Phainon, making shooing motions with her hands where Castorice can't see them.

Phainon stands up, pulling Mydei with him. "We'll head out, then," he says. "Get better, Cas."

She looks startled. "'Cas?'"

"A nickname," Phainon explains, smiling, "if we're going to be friends."

"I…" She purses her lips. "Oh."

There's a stack of sticky notes and a can filled with pens on Hyacine's desk. Mydei reaches for them and pens his number down. "I'll leave our numbers with you," he says. "Call if you need anything. Or if you don't." Phainon takes the sticky note next, writing his too, then passes it to Hyacine, who takes up the last of the space and sticks the paper to the edge of the exam table, safely out of range of Castorice's hands until she peels it off and folds it into quarters to slip into her pocket.

"Thank you," she says softly. "All of you."

"Of course," Hyacine says, so gently. "We'll let you get some rest."

△

Aglaea is waiting for them when they get back. "So?" she asks, seated on the couch with one leg crossed over the other, managing to look oddly glamorous in a pale yellow t-shirt tucked into white sweatpants. There's a good chance she already knows just how their mission went.

"We found her," Mydei says carefully, not wanting to say anything too incriminating. "There were some… issues, and she's concussed, but fine. She's staying in the infirmary tonight, and we're going to figure things out in the morning."

"Right," Aglaea says. "I'll speak to her when I have the chance. Do you have anything to add about the state you left the hotel in right after you showed your faces to everyone there?"

They were seen by maybe one patron and the front desk lady, but it's still enough to be a nuisance for Aglaea to clean up later. Especially with Castorice missing after they asked about her specifically. Phainon bends at the waist. "We're sorry," he says, and doesn't bother trying to explain away the problem. Aglaea already knows. A tug at Mydei's wrist, and he mumbles an apology too, already anticipating whatever punishment Aglaea will concoct.

"Yes, yes, I'll take care of it," she says coolly. "But there are a couple of things that need to be done around the apartment in the meantime. I trust

you two don’t mind helping.”

Mydei chews on the inside of his cheek. “Not at all,” he tries. It comes out all weak.

“Good,” Aglaea says, and now there’s the tiniest hint of a smile on her face. She’s always been a sadist with no humanity. “I look forward to having a sparkling fridge and freezer. It’ll cheer me up wonderfully after Anaxagoras and I are done taking care of the fallout.”

“Of course,” Phainon croaks, looking slightly nauseated.

Aglaea stands and nods to them. “I’ll leave you to it, then.” When she leaves, Mydei and Phainon look at each other.

“It needs to be done anyway,” Phainon offers, trying to be optimistic. His smile wavers at the edges. His complexion is already turning green. “Think of how nice it’ll be when we’re done. We won’t have to hold our noses every time we open the fridge.”

“This is your fault, you know,” Mydei tells him, pressing a finger to the center of his chest. A warm hand immediately comes up to hold his wrist. “If you hadn’t broken the door and caused a scene—”

“I distinctly remember you wanting me to break the lock,” Phainon says, raising an eyebrow. And he’s right. They made this mess together. They’ll clean the fridge together too. Mydei deflates, making a face at him.

“Let’s just get this over with.”

△

It takes an unreasonably long time to take everything out of the fridge and lay it out on the counter. Phainon takes care of cleaning the fridge itself—full of mysterious spills and crumbs and gunk of all colors—while Mydei takes care of checking expiration dates and tossing out everything that’s gone bad. He can’t decide who has the shorter end of the stick. Phainon has

to deal with the gunk, Mydei has to scrape moldy leftovers into the trash. Both are pretty terrible.

"Mydei," Phainon says after a bit. He’s squatting in front of the open fridge, a rag in one hand and his shirt over his nose with the other. A bottle of cleaner and another of disinfectant wipes sit by his feet. Mydei looks at him from where he’s scraping some concoction of Cipher’s from at least two months ago into the trash. It smells like fish and rot and the sight of it alone is almost enough to set off his gag reflex. “What happened with her?”

Mydei opens his mouth, closes it. “What do you mean?”

"I mean…” Phainon pauses, trying to scrub at something for a moment before he gives up and pulls the whole top shelf out of the fridge to move into the sink to clean. He kicks the bottles out of the way of the door, and then they’re back to back, not looking at each other anymore. “You said she came back here a while ago. Why didn’t you tell anyone, and why are you so set on saving her now?”

Mydei doesn't know what to say. “You are too,” he tries, setting the container aside to wash once he manages to get the worst of the spoiled food out.

A laugh. “Sure,” Phainon agrees. “But it’s *me.* I have the biggest hero complex out of anyone ever; of course I want to save her too. But why *you?”*

He grunts. “Am I not allowed to want to save people?”

“Don’t act dumb,” Phainon says, gently, knowingly. He has Mydei memorized as well as his own hands.

Mydei is quiet for a breath, two. He exhales out of his mouth because the smell is too much. Water running, the pop of the cap to the dish soap, the sound of a sponge scrubbing. “...I didn’t tell anyone because she didn’t want me to, and… I want to save her because she has nowhere else to go and… you’re the one who said it first. I guess she reminded me of me.”

"Okay," Phainon says softly.

“I know what it’s like, maybe not as bad as her, but…” The whole first half of Mydei’s life was spent fighting, fighting, fighting until he didn’t know how to do anything else. He got so used to blood on his hands that he forgot what they looked like clean. He barely trusted anyone, just like Castorice. He remembers seeing Phainon hands, burnt and blistered. He healed slowly and painfully. And Castorice— Today she looked at Phainon and the first thought in her head was if she'd hurt him. Those aren’t thought people have if they *want* to cause pain. She’s much gentler than Mydei had been, but he gets it. "I just..."

“I think I understand,” Phainon says softly. “*You* reminded *me* of me too, you know? You were so… vengeful, and I wanted to see you remember how to smile the same way I did. Sometimes it’s just like that. Like calls to like, or whatever. Strays call to strays.”

Mydei turns to look at him, finds him turned too. His eyes are so stupidly blue, so stupidly understanding. He and Phainon don't talk like this a lot; they bury everything important deep like they’ll choke on it if they don’t. "What the fuck," Mydei breathes.

"Yeah," Phainon laughs. "It's like that, isn't it."

“Shut up,” Mydei says, and turns back to the trash. A bottle of thousand island dressing, three years expired. He twists off the cap and starts to squeeze it into the garbage so he can recycle the bottle.

"Do you need a hug?" Phainon asks, and he’d be terribly warm. They’ve long since learned how they fit together. Mydei knows the width of him, the spots where he’s soft and the spots where he’s hard with muscle. Phainon gives good fucking hugs, but it would be embarrassing to want one now.

“Fuck off,” Mydei tells him instead, shaking the bottle hard as orange liquid splatters against the side of the trash bag.

“Yeah, okay,” Phainon laughs. The tap turns back on as he rinses the shelf, glass clanging as he clumsily maneuvers it in the sink. There’s a good

chance they’ll hold each other in bed tonight regardless, and that way Mydei won’t have to admit that he wants it. Phainon always comes to him first. “I’m here if you need it.”

△

The next day, when Cipher and Aglaea come home from their obligations for the day, Mydei bites the bullet and says, "Let's get a cat."

Aglaea pauses. Cipher kind of gapes at him, ears perking. "Like… Actually?” she asks. “You’re a hundred percent serious right now?”

"I'm down," Phainon calls from the living room.

So Mydei gathers his resolve and says again, "Let's get a cat. I mean it." And no one really protests, so they go adopt a cat. Phainon finds a nice no-kill shelter where the animals are kept in their own little rooms instead of cages and they just... go.

Mydei peers through the glass door into one of the rooms. Phainon's in there with a gray tabby named Vigethos. He's looking at him slightly suspiciously, but he lets Phainon pet him after a thorough sniff. After a while, he stands up and leaves the cat with a little scratch on the head. Mydei takes his place, but the material of his pants rustles too much and Vigethos seems scared of him, so he gives up quickly.

They split up. Mydei meets an Oatmeal, a Fig Stew, and a Nanus. Fig Stew is sweet, but his sheet says he gets overstimulated and would prefer a calm, quiet household, and Mydei doesn’t think they’re equipped to give him that with Phainon and Cipher in the house. Oatmeal is very aloof, and Nanus hisses when Aglaea so much as tries to come near him, so those options are out too.

They move along. Cipher and Aglaea attempt to visit Vigethos, and Mydei stops in front of the door where Phainon has been holed away for a while. Mydei knocks softly on the door, and Phainon waves him in. Mydei holds his pants so they don't make so much noise and edges inside. He's slow and quiet as he comes to crouch next to Phainon on the floor.

On one of the shelves is a cat bed covered by a light blue blanket. The cat inside is mottled with white and blue gray fur. A paw hanging out of the bed is white, like he’s wearing a tiny little sock, and Mydei’s heart does terrible things.

"His name is Bubbles," Phainon says softly, making room for Mydei to hold out a hand. Bubbles looks at him warily, but he stretches forward and sniffs. After a moment, he butts his head against Mydei’s fingers, and Mydei pets him gently with his heart in his throat. "He was purring earlier, but I think he got scared when you came in, maybe he'll— ah. There he goes." Bubbles starts again, purring quietly, blinking slowly when Mydei scratches under his chin.

"Shit," Mydei whispers. Bubbles moves his head a little, so he scratches under his ears instead.

"I think," Phainon starts, reaching out so they can pet Bubbles together, "if it's up to me, he's the one."

“Why did I think I was a dog person?” Mydei mumbles when Bubbles nudges happily against him. He slow blinks back when Bubbles does, and he’s half certain the purring gets louder.

"Why'd you suggest we get a cat, if you thought you liked dogs better?" Phainon asks, shifting on the floor, leaning his head on Mydei’s shoulder. He pets Bubbles’ body, all the way down to his white-tipped tail, playing with it until Bubbles flicks it out of his grip, his purrs not faltering once.

Mydei glances at him. White hair tickles his cheek, and then Phainon tips his face up to look back. They’re close, too close. If they weren’t in public, this would probably end with their mouths pressed together. Mydei purses his lips, rubs his thumb between the cat’s eyes. "I figured you and Cipher would be happier with one. Aglaea probably doesn't care either way."

"Oh," Phainon says simply. "That's sweet of you."

Mydei's face feels warm. He gives Bubbles one last pet and quietly stands up, nudging Phainon off his shoulder before he can do or say something

embarrassing. "Yeah," he says. "He's got my vote. Let’s find Cipher and Aglaea, so they can meet him too."

Cipher and Aglaea love him too, because it’s probably impossible to hate a creature like Bubbles. Phainon takes Bubbles' paper out of the plastic sheet taped outside his door, and they adopt him. It's a lot of waiting. They have to file some paperwork and wait some more. Mydei goes with Aglaea to check out the shelter's shop, and they pick out some toys and a package of treats. They'll have to go to the pet store after this for food and a litter box and whatever else, because Mydei hadn't thought that far when he decided on this.

Six minutes later, the employee going over their paperwork folds up a cardboard cat carrier and tells them she's getting him for them. Phainon clings to Mydei’s arm. Aglaea fiddles with the cat toys they bought. Cipher is probably somewhere exploring. For some reason, they're all nervous. They wait a little longer. Five minutes or so, the employee brings Bubbles out. He's yowling, pacing around inside the box and crying when she sets him down to hand the paperwork back to Mydei, and then they just... have a cat. Phainon carries him. His eyes are watery the whole way home.

They let Bubbles out in the bathroom when they get back. Cipher and Phainon undo either side of the cardboard carrier, and as soon as it's open, Bubbles jumps out and hides behind the toilet. His eyes are wide and scared, and they'd been told this kind of behavior is normal, but Mydei's heart breaks a little.

"Let's all back up," Phainon says, voice low and soft and non-threatening. "He's probably overwhelmed; let's leave him alone for a bit."

"Yeah," Mydei breathes. Quietly, they creep out of the bathroom. Phainon closes the door most of the way and flicks off the light to give Bubbles some peace. They regroup on the couch.

"You two," Aglaea says, crossing her legs and pointing at Mydei and Phainon, "shall go to the store and procure him food and a litter box. Buy the good stuff. Cipher and I will stay back in case anything happens.”

"Right," Cipher says, smiling a bit too widely, tail swishing.

"Right," Mydei echoes. Phainon nods back.

"Hurry," Aglaea says. "Come home before he needs to use the litterbox."

So Mydei and Phainon go together to the pet store. They buy a litter box, two bags of clumping litter, a pooper scooper, a bag of fancy organic kibble and an even fancier case of wet cat food. They wander around for fear of forgetting things. Phainon finds an elevated food and water holder with stainless steel bowls, so they get that too. A few more toys are next, because it can't hurt to have options, then a two pack of cardboard cat scratching pads, because that can't hurt either. The last thing they get is a cat bed, big and soft and fuzzy. The cashier rings them up for... a lot of money. Mydei can’t even bring himself to feel regret.

They bring it all home. Phainon carries it in, taking the supplies for the litterbox to set up in the bathroom.

"He's still in there," Cipher warns him, "Don’t be loud and scary."

They try not to be loud and scary. Mydei helps Phainon pour litter in the box and spread it evenly. They push the litterbox next to the toilet, leaning the bags of litter against the wall and sticking the poop scoop in a plastic bag. The way Bubbles watches them is less wary and more curious. He's still behind the toilet. Mydei holds out a careful hand to him, blinking slowly when they make eye contact. Bubbles sniffs, and then he blinks back. Mydei's heart trembles in his chest as he sets his hand on the cat's little forehead. And really, he's so little, maybe not for his species but for Mydei's big hands.

"You like him," Phainon murmurs, a little bit teasing, more than a little bit fond.

Mydei grunts. "Of course I love him." A couple of head scratches later, Bubbles stands up. He stretches a bit, and then he comes out from behind the toilet and pads closer, sniffing Mydei's knee and then tentatively moving to Phainon, who gives up on where he's been reading the label on the bag of

kibble to offer a hand up for inspection. Bubbles spends a little longer on him, and then he edges his face up for some pets, and Phainon barely touches him before a tiny rumble of a purr builds up in his chest.

"I think he likes me better," Phainon says, lips curling up.

Mydei tries not to show that this peeves him. “...He doesn’t know us yet. Give it time.”

Cipher cracks the door open. Bubbles's purr stops when he sees her, and he takes a couple of steps back when she edges inside. She has a can of wet cat food in one hand and a freshly washed bowl in the other. “He’s probably hungry,” she says as softly as he’s ever heard her speak, sitting on the floor, ears twitching. Bubbles warms to her quickly, maybe because she’s a cat too. Phainon and Mydei scoot to make room for her.

Bubbles approaches, sniffing Cipher, rubbing his cheek against the can of food. He paces between the three of them, walking circles, pausing for pets before moving to inspect the cupboards or the bathtub or something on the ground. Cipher cracks the can open, and his ears perk.

Cipher chuckles, scraping the food into the bowl. “He knows,” she says, letting him sniff the lid but pulling it back before he can try to lick it and hurt himself on the sharp edges. “It’s the good stuff, dude. Salmon, my favorite too.”

Bubbles chirps softly. The door creaks again, and there’s Aglaea in the frame, though she doesn’t try to come all the way inside and scare Bubbles again. The smell of the cat food permeates the room, and Bubbles is a messy eater, but the four of them watch, and this is what Mydei imagines it feels like to have a family.

△

Mydei wakes up later than he means to, but this is how most days go for him. He sets an alarm but struggles to wake for it, regardless of whether he got ten hours of sleep or four. Phainon is already up, his side of the bed rumpled and cold.

Bubbles is still in the bathroom, though they've cracked the door open a little wider so he can see the rest of the apartment, even if he isn't interested in exploring quite yet. Mydei isn't sure if they're doing this right, but he's just been sitting in the bed they got for him, and he doesn't seem nearly as nervous as he did the night before.

Phainon manages to lure him into the hallway with treats after breakfast, but Bubbles doesn't get very far before he hears Cipher screaming in another room and scampers back to the bathroom. It's fine. He's making progress, and Mydei knows it isn't easy, acclimating to a new space. He was the same when he first came here. Maybe not to the point of hiding behind the toilet, but they all were, to some extent.

After he eats and gives Bubbles a few pets, he heads back to the infirmary. Hyacine looks at Mydei like she isn't expecting him to be there at all. "Mydei?" she asks, kind of confused. She looks Mydei over like she's looking for injuries, and Mydei realizes he hasn't been here alone since... ever. Not when he hardly ever goes on missions.

"I'm not hurt," he says, a little awkward. Hyacine just blinks at him, and he starts to feel embarrassed for some reason. "Is, ah... Is Castorice still here?" He can't see her anywhere, and the door to the room in the back is wide open and empty, the bed inside neatly made.

"You just missed her," Hyacine tells him. "We've found a temporary residence she's agreed to stay at, at least while she recovers from the concussion and we deal with the Cleaners. She's alright, if you're worried."

"A temporary residence?" Mydei repeats.

Hyacine nods slowly, and again, Mydei is asking himself why he's here. He thought to be a familiar face, but it seems he isn't needed at all. He doesn't know why he thought he would be. It's already midday anyway, of course they're already done setting everything up. "For her privacy, I probably shouldn't tell you where it is…"

"Yeah," Mydei says. "Yeah, no. Don't. The less people that know the better if we're going to keep her safe. Just thought I'd… uh…"

Hyacine smiles. “I’ll let her know you stopped by,” she offers. “I’m sure it’ll be nice to know she has friends here. She’ll be resting for a while, though.”

“Yeah, of course,” Mydei says, regretful and embarrassed and awkward at once. Why is he here? Titans above. “Thanks.”

He grinds his forehead into his palm on the way home.

△

“Did you go to the infirmary?” Phainon asks later. He’s deep in the process of struggling into his gear, fighting with straps and craning his neck to try to see behind him. Mydei watches him for a bit before he comes up and grabs his shoulders to make him stop so he can help with the straps in the back of Phainon’s vest, making sure they’re secure.

“I did,” Mydei says. Another day, another job. This time, Aglaea is taking Phainon to scope out the Cleaner’s hideout. Her enhanced senses and his super strength make a killer combo for that sort of thing. As he fixes the last of the straps, Phainon goes quiet and still. “Is that a problem?”

“No,” Phainon says, but it comes out a bit weird.

“Phainon.”

“It’s not,” Phainon insists. He turns around, and Mydei busies himself with the buckles on Phainon’s front too, though he can easily do these ones up himself. In a way, it’s just an excuse to be close to him. Mydei always feels like he needs an excuse. Either Phianon is the one who wants it, or there’s something stuck on his clothes, or he needs bandages wrapped, something like that. But Titans know Mydei just likes having Phainon close to him. Phainon would welcome it either way, he’s sure, but he can never bring himself to get close just because *Mydei* is the one who wants it.

“Then why are you being weird?” Mydei asks. His hands pause, he lifts his head to look at Phainon. His expression, brows slightly furrowed, mouth

turned down. They're close enough that he can feel Phainon's body heat, hear his breath. "Are you jealous?"

"Shut up," Phainon says, hands brushing Mydei's as he pulls one of his straps tighter. "I'm not."

"You were out, or I would've taken you with me," Mydei tells him. He knows what Phainon looks like, jealous. Sad and clingy, like an attention-starved dog. "Castorice wasn't even there."

"That isn't it." Phainon shakes his head. His fingertips land on Mydei's waist. His head falls forward onto Mydei's shoulder, a warm weight. Reflex, Mydei's hand slips into his hair.

"Then what is?"

Phainon makes an unhappy noise. His grip grows firmer, greedy, palms on the small of Mydei's back, pulling him closer. He hugs so tightly, the hard parts of his body armor digging into Mydei in his casual clothes. Maybe it's the super strength; he could crush Mydei completely if he wanted to, but he's soft enough, and for some reason Mydei trusts him with his life, his everything.

"Phainon," he says again. "Why is it upsetting that I went to the infirmary?"

"It's not,"Phainon insists. He sounds petulant and embarrassed at the same time. "It's just… You went to see her, you *keep* going to see her. I know you said you just care because she's a stray like the rest of us, but… she's pretty, isn't she? And you're probably the only person on this planet that can touch her. What if she gets the wrong idea, or something? What if you…"

An incredulous laugh bubbles up in Mydei's throat, but he bites his tongue to keep it down. "Are you stupid?" he asks, putting his free hand on Phainon's hip and pressing him back. One step, two, they stumble. He pushes Phainon into the door, coming close. "Do you think I fall in love with everyone I meet?"

“How could you?” Phainon asks, unsteady, hands flexing on Mydei’s waist. His breath hitches in his throat when Mydei pulls the skin of his jaw between his teeth, lets it go, kisses the spot to soothe the sting. “When—When you didn’t fall in love with me?”

Mydei pauses, breathes him in. Gunmetal and cypress. He pulls back just a bit, so they can look at each other. Phainon’s eyes are dark, glued to him. “Is that what this is?” Mydei asks. His thumbs slip under the edge of Phainon’s undershirt. There’s a strange feeling in his chest. “You’re not jealous, you’re just…”

He watches the shift of the muscles in Phainon’s throat as he swallows. They’ve been messing around like this as long as he can remember, but never has either of them called it love, and Mydei likes to pretend that he isn’t the one who wants it. Phainon’s just as good at pretending, but no wonder he’s uncertain too. And fuck, Mydei had always assumed they were fine, that Phainon was fine.

“I haven’t kissed a soul since you,” Phainon breathes.

Mydei can hear his own heartbeat. He pretends, but he does want it. He doesn’t say it, but he could, if Phainon needs to hear it. His heart beats, beats, beats. Phainon’s vest is firm against him. Heat, where his fingers have slipped underneath. He’ll make himself sick just to say it, “I haven’t loved a soul since you.”

Phainon’s eyes flicking between his. His puff of breath. His lips part. “You—”

“Phaiiiiiinon,” Cipher calls from the hallway. Mydei takes a step back as she swings the door open, frowning, a little bit disgruntled. “Aglaea says to get your ass out there or you’re going to throw everything off schedule.”

“Right,” Phainon says. The way he looks at Mydei for just a second longer before he peels himself away from the wall and out the door. Mydei’s heart beats, beats, beats.

Cipher squints at him. “What’s up with you?”

△

"What’s wrong with us?" Mydei asks, elbows propped on his knees, unable to let this go. The look on Phainon’s face as he left, his voice when he said *I haven’t kissed a soul since you,* the feeling of his hands, his breath, his body. What is this, *why* is this? Why did he say it?

"Fuck," he breathes, with feeling. Bubbles blinks slowly at him from his cat bed, one white-tipped paw curled over the edge. Mydei slides off the toilet seat to sit in front of him. "Bubbles," he says, letting the cat sniff him, "what's wrong with us?"

They don’t do this, they don’t say this, they never have, and now Mydei doesn’t even know what Phainon was going to say in reply. Nothing bad, he doesn’t think. Phainon wouldn’t just… reject him, after all this, after all that. But Mydei had been the first one to say it outright, and there’s a feeling that comes with that like nausea, like illness. Phainon is on a job, and Mydei can do nothing but wait, and it’s unbearable.

Bubbles butts against his hand, so Mydei pets him, lightly scratching his forehead, the thinner patches of fur in front of his ears, and Bubbles starts to purr, the sound vibrating his whole body when Mydei presses a hand to his side. When he runs a gentle finger over Bubbles’ exposed paw, he swiftly pulls it back, curling it under his tiny little body as the rumble ceases.

Mydei feels a little bit guilty for this too, but Bubbles is swift to forgive him with a few more head scratches, his eyes squeezing shut, head tipping into Mydei’s hand, and he starts to purr again. It’s quieter than he does with Phainon, but it’s something. Mydei wants to lay down and press his ear to his side so he can feel it rumble through him, but he doesn't. Bubbles doesn’t trust him enough for that yet. This is fine, the soft sound of it in the air, the smoothness of his fur, the calmness of his closed eyes.

Some time passes. Not much, but Mydei could probably pass an hour just petting the cat. A bit longer, and his phone rings.

It's an unknown number, so he almost ignores it. Almost being key, because after it rings twice he realizes who it might be, and he picks up. "Hello?" he

says. There's only silence on the other end. A beat, and then there's an inhale.

"You said," comes a voice, high and soft and a little bit raspy around the edges, "I could call, if I need anything."

"Or if you don't," Mydei adds. More silence. "Are you alright?"

"Fine," Castorice says, "I've just been resting most of the day." She breathes in again, then out, and Mydei wonders how unsteady she must be for it to be audible over the phone. "Look, I…"

"Castorice," Mydei says, as soft as someone like him can manage. She cuts off. Again, Mydei asks, "Are you alright?"

"My head hurts a bit," She admits. "I dialed your number wrong three times because I couldn't focus."

"That might just be my handwriting," Mydei says. She doesn't laugh. He doesn't expect her to. Bubbles bats lightly at him when his hand goes limp, so he starts scratching the cat's head again.

"They put me in an apartment," Castorice continues after a while. "Hyacine says I can stay as long as I like, but..." She pauses. She never finishes her sentence. "I'm sorry for wasting your time. I don't know why I—"

"You're welcome wherever," Mydei reminds her. She's more afraid than he'd been. He'd been angry, so used to causing hurt that all he did was lash out again and again. In her it's the opposite. She's so used to causing hurt that she'd rather walk on glass and hurt herself than anyone else. "We're friends, here. All of us come from difficult backgrounds, but we stick together, and it makes it a little bit better."

A longer silence this time. He can't hear Castorice's breath. "I've been alone all my life," she admits. "I don't… know what that's supposed to look like."

Mydei thinks about this. He thinks about this, and he says, "I don't either. I don't think it's *supposed* to look like anything." Castorice lets out this little

hum. "I'm sorry," Mydei adds, "for the record. I don't think I ever said so, but I'm sorry I scared you and made you fall."

"That was on me," Castorice says, kind of confused.

"No," Mydei says, and leaves it at that. It's quiet between them again. There's a lot of that. Quiet. Phainon or Cipher could fill it, but Mydei has never been good at that.

"I'm… not upset with you," Castorice says, "not for that, or… anything else. I didn't run because I was scared of you, I ran because I didn't *know* it was you. I thought you were the Cleaners." She said that before. She'd have gone if she'd known. Bubbles stands up, pushing off his hand, and circles the cat bed once, twice before he settles back down with a little huff.

"What are you trying to do?" Mydei wonders, more to himself than to her, watching the cat's eyes shut, his side rising and falling. "Where are you going from here?"

"I don't know," Castorice says. Softer, "I just don't want to hurt people anymore."

"No one here would ever ask you to," Mydei tells her. It's easy to say, hard to believe. Trust is hard earned between people like them. He knows staying isn't that easy of a choice. "We're taking care of the Cleaners."

"Good," Castorice says tiredly. She breathes, just once, and then says, "My head is starting to hurt again. I should get some rest."

She hangs up before Mydei can say goodbye.

△

Phainon and Aglaea come back around the time Mydei is preparing dinner and Cipher is sitting on top of the newly cleaned fridge, having used the counter as a step stool to climb up. She's been peering down at him every time he reaches for ingredients, folding over herself every now and then to play with his hair if he bends down to get something on the bottom shelf.

She hisses at him when he flicks her tail, draped over the side of the fridge, in response.

The rice has just finished cooking, and the green curry he made is perfectly fragrant when the door opens and they come in, a bit ruffled but otherwise unhurt.

“Welcome home,” Cipher says, and Aglaea looks at her sitting on the fridge and frowns. Phainon beelines straight for his room, bogged down by his gear or unwilling to look Mydei in the face. Cipher watches him go, tail swishing, then turns back to Aglaea. “Good mission?”

A sigh. “Get down from there,” Aglaea says, and disappears to her room too.

Cipher sits a little longer, then slides off the fridge onto the counter, then back onto the floor. “Tough crowd,” she says, sniffing and fixing the falling strap of her tank top.

“Put those back,” Mydei says, gesturing to the cereal boxes she’d cleared off the fridge to make room for herself. She grumbles something and starts, tip-toeing to reach. Mydei dishes up a plate for himself, squeezing a wedge of lime over top and sitting at the dining table. He takes a picture of it, then digs in. Cipher comes around with a plate of her own after a moment, scooping some of the curry up to sniff. She smells the rice too, then the lime before she squeezes it, and then she eats. Maybe a feline habit of hers, maybe something born of scrapping on the streets and having to check things for rot. Mydei hasn’t asked.

Aglaea comes out a little while later, hair pulled back with a clip, dressed in white loungewear. She dishes up a plate, thanks Mydei politely, and takes the seat next to Cipher. A handful of minutes pass. Aglaea gives the play-by-play of the mission, detailing the intel they’d recovered and what she anticipates the plan will be from here. Another handful of minutes. Mydei finishes his food and sets the plate in the sink, and then he slips down the hallway to Phainon’s room to rap on the door thrice.

It swings open, and there's Phainon with wet hair and pajamas like he just showered. "I wasn't avoiding you," he says, too quickly. "I was sweaty."

"Sure," Mydei says, stepping forward, backing him out of the way of the door and shutting it behind them both. It's a cool, solid weight against his back. "I made green curry."

"My favorite," Phainon says, and kind of stands there, because Mydei is blocking the door. His mouth parts. He wets his lips, rocks on his feet. "Listen—"

"What are you scared of?" Mydei interrupts him. "I'm the one who said it and got left without an answer. You could've at least said 'me too' or something on the way out the door." He folds his arms over his chest, lifting his eyebrows expectantly, and lets Phainon flounder for words, just for a bit, before he continues.

"I trust you," he says. "There's a measure of uncertainty with any mission, but I always trust that you'll come back. So I wait, and I cook dinner like your goddamn housewife, and if I tell you I love you before you go, the least you can do is say it back." *Just in case you don't come home,* is something he doesn't say, but it hangs in the air regardless.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says.

"Why?" Mydei asks. "Because you didn't say it back, or because you can't?"

He comes closer, stuck to Mydei like tree sap, but they don't touch. He just frowns, far more severe than he ever is. "Why is that even in question?" He shakes his head. "I'm in love with you. I'm so in love with you it makes me look stupid, and you know it. I just never thought I'd hear it come out of your mouth."

"Right," Mydei says drily. "Because I would do all the things I do with you with any good pal."

“It’s not like you *said* anything,” Phainon reminds him. Another step closer, they’re sharing space, air. His damp hair curls up at the ends. “And sure, I didn’t either. But I thought I was obvious, at least.”

“So did I.”

Phainon’s eyebrows climb his forehead. He sets his hands on Mydei’s hips, takes another step into him until they’re pressed hip to hip. “I beg to share your bed like… three times a week. I say sappy, embarrassing things to you all the time, I initiate it about ninety percent of the time we kiss or hold hands or—”

“Fine,” Mydei cuts him off. “I get it. I’m bad at this too.”

A breathy laugh. Phainon’s forehead leans against his own, wet hair tickling, the scent of tea tree shampoo and woodsy soap on him from his shower. “Check the mirror before you rail on someone else,” he says. “But it’s okay. I’ll still love you even if you’re shy.”

It does a horrible thing to Mydei’s chest to hear him say it. So casual, easy as breathing. “Who’s fucking shy?”

Again, Phainon laughs a little. He has a laugh like music, though Mydei will never tell him that. “Did you know you cling in your sleep?” Phainon asks him. His voice is soft, his nose nudging against Mydei’s. “I have to give you a pillow to hug or you won’t let me go in the morning.”

“Now you’re just making shit up,” Mydei says, winding his arms around Phainon’s shoulders, almost kissing him but holding back.

“If it makes you feel better to believe that,” Phainon says, “but I think you know, because sometimes you pretend to be asleep just so you have an excuse to hold me a little longer.”

“Shut—” Phainon kisses him before he can finish speaking, and his mouth is in an odd shape for it but they make it work, and he forgets that he was pissed off just for a second before he slides both hands to Phainon’s chest

and shoves him off. “Why do you think you are?” he asks, but he’s grinning, titans above, he’s grinning.

Phainon grins back. “The guy you’re in love with,” he says. Mydei smacks him again, and he laughs. “What? Am I wrong?”

△

“I want to go on more missions,” Mydei says, nerves steeled as he stands in front of Aglaea while she reads a magazine. She looks up at him with green-gold eyes and blinks.

“Very well,” she says, and pauses. “Your heart rate is very fast. Has something made you nervous?”

Mydei’s mouth falls open, closes again. “Was there not… a reason why you usually keep me back?”

Again, she blinks. “When you decided to settle here, you had said you had no interest in risking your life on the daily for our cause. I had assumed that still stood, so I only ask for your help when you are indispensable.”

It’s been *years* since he said anything like that. All the way back when he was still an outsider, before he fell head first into whatever this is. Does he really talk to Aglaea so little, that she would still think that stands? After *years?* “No,” he says, incredulous. “That hasn’t stood for a long time.”

“Well… Pardon my inattentiveness if you’ve been bored at home. Both your power and your skill in combat will be of much use to us.” Aglaea closes the magazine and sets it on her knee. “We’ll be taking out that Cleaner’s hideout in four days time, and you’re more than welcome to join us.”

Behind her and to the right, Bubbles peeks his head out of the hallway for the first time since he’d come home with them, taking slow, slinking steps, ears low on his head, sniffing the air. When he notices Mydei looking, he perks up and gives a soft, chirpy meow. At Mydei’s shocked expression,

Aglaea chuckles without even turning, sure to have long since heard him coming.

“Yes,” she says, “he’s been doing that. He’s far less sneaky than he thinks he is. Just like you and Phainon.”

△

Castorice calls late the next day, when Mydei is laying with Phainon in bed, tracing patterns into his ribs over his shirt, listening to him explain how he got a scar on the inside of his knee climbing a barbed wire fence. 11:53, just before midnight, his phone rings, and Phainon trails off. When Mydei shows him the caller ID, his eyes go wide, and Mydei presses accept.

"Hello," he says, and a beat passes, two.

“Did you mean it, last time, when you said I could have a place here?” Castorice asks. Phainon is still staring wide-eyed. He prods at Mydei’s shoulder until he answers.

“Yes, I meant it.” It feels too late for this. Long since dark outside. Quiet. Mydei wonders what she's thinking. He wonders if she's lonely, or scared, or something else.

She hangs up.

The tone rings in Mydei's ear. He props his phone on Phainon’s chest and looks at it, but she doesn't call back.

“That was… odd,” Phainon says. His fingers slip through Mydei’s hair, lazy and rhythmic. “Should we call her back?”

“No,” Mydei decides, turning his phone and lingering here a little longer. They’re both too muscled to be all that comfortable cuddled up against each other like this, but it doesn’t matter. He lingers as he always does, long enough that a handful of minutes go by, and then he pushes himself up. Phainon does too, already opening his mouth to ask what he’s doing or where he’s going when Mydei’s phone buzzes again. A text, he checks it.

Open the door. A moment passes. A second text: *Please.*

Mydei stares, reads it thrice. “She’s here,” he says, and drags himself out of bed to open the door, Phainon close behind. Castorice stands outside in the hallway, dressed in gloves and long sleeves. Deja vu. Mydei looks at her wordlessly, the door wide open.

“Hi,” Phainon says, and her gaze flicks between him and Mydei.

“...Hi,” she says, folding her hands in front of her, wringing her fingers.

"Why are you here?" Mydei asks, trying to gentle his words before they can come out accusatory. It's late. It's dark; they hadn't even turned on the lights, and the outside corridor is dimly lit and smelling of night air. Cipher and Aglaea are sleeping. Bubbles too, in the bathroom.

"My apartment," Castorice says, "is small and empty and only about three people know where it is. The longer I'm there the more the sound of the wind drives me crazy."

"So you came here," Mydei says. Phainon’s hand curls around his wrist, and Castorice’s gaze flicks to that too. She falters, whatever confidence she’d had slipping like sand between her fingers.

"...So I came here," she agrees, voice small. Mydei steps aside to let her in and closes the door behind her, Phainon’s fingers falling away. Castorice stands a safe distance away, and she looks like she feels terribly out of place. Phainon turns on a light.

"Do you want the couch?" Mydei asks, reaching for Phainon’s hand and pulling him a few feet down the hallway to the coat closet, stuffed with extra blankets and pillows.

"That's..." Castorice goes quiet. She takes the blankets Phainon holds out to her, the pillow Mydei does. She’s careful not to touch them, and Mydei studies her expression. "Thank you," she says, a bit baffled, swiftly breaking eye contact, stepping back so they aren't so close, letting them lead

the way into the living room. She sits gingerly on the couch, pulling her legs up, setting the pillow behind her and stacking the blankets on her lap.

"What you asked, earlier," Mydei says. Castorice looks up at him, face carefully blank. "Were you serious?"

Castorice swallows visibly and looks away again. Her gloved fingers twist in her lap. "And what about you? Were you serious?"

He'd felt that way too, wondered why anyone would want a half-feral, half-drowned kid as a friend and a part of the family. But they did, and here he is, with a purpose and people who love him, even if it comes with a bit of danger. He's not sure he'd like a mundane life anyway. Once, there was a time when that was all he wished for.

He sits on the opposite end of the couch, giving her plenty of space, dragging Phainon along with him. "Yes," he says, "I was."

"I…" Phainon hesitates, wetting his lips and glancing at Mydei before he continues speaking. "I don't know what all Mydei has told you about us, but… We're all like you, in a way. My house burned down and killed my whole family, and I was on the streets for a few months before Aglaea found me. I wasn't sure about staying either, but… we're good people. Or, I like to think so." He laughs weakly, scrubs the back of his neck. "I meant what *I* said earlier, too. About being a friend, if you want that. I can't speak for everyone else, but I highly doubt any of them would say no."

"If you want a place," Mydei says softly.

"I owe you all a lot already," Castorice murmurs, hugging one of the blankets close to her chest. Her lower lip wobbles, chin dimpling. "I just don't want to hurt anyone anymore."

"No one here will make you," Mydei promises her again, and waits. The offer is there; Castorice just needs to take it. A hard choice, he knows, to someone so scarred and scared of trusting.

"Okay." Castorice nods once, swallows. “I want to believe you. You’ve all been nothing but kind to me.”

“We know how hard it is to believe in something like this, trust me,” Phainon says. He laughs a little, nostalgic, knuckles brushing Mydei’s thigh until their hands twine together. “You can take a year to decide, if you need. Two. You have our numbers; feel free to come and go as much as you want.”

Castorice looks conflicted at this too. She won’t want to be on the run anymore. She must be tired of it, bone weary to the point of breaking down, too exhausted to keep being afraid. Starved of safety. Mydei’s been there too.

The floorboards creak as Aglaea comes down the hallway, dressed in a yellow nightgown that buttons up the front. “Lovely to have a visitor,” she says, taking a seat in one of the armchairs beside the couch. Her hair still looks perfect, even this late. They must’ve woken her, despite how hushed they’ve been. “Castorice, yes? It’s a pleasure to finally meet you in person.”

At her arrival, Castorice looks terribly embarrassed. She stands and bows at the waist, lengthy ponytails slipping over her shoulder and just about brushing the floor. “I apologize if we woke you up,” she says helplessly. “I only meant to…”

“Relax,” Aglaea says, smiling a bit. She has a cold, calculating smile, but it seems that even she’s trying to soften herself now. Slowly, Castorice sits back down.

“I’m happy to arrange for your extended stay,” Aglaea continues after a moment. “How long that’s for, whether just a week or permanently is up to you. Unfortunately, we can’t just house you for free.” She pauses, and Castorice stiffens. “Mission work is how most of us earn our keep, but I understand if that’s undesirable to you. Do you sew, perhaps? Or are you handy with tools? There are a number of things that need mending around here, but it can be a bit difficult to explain certain things around here to hired help.”

“I…” Castorice opens her mouth, closes it. “Yes, I… Can help with those kinds of things, but… Surely a bit of work like that isn’t enough to pay for rent or… whatever else.”

Aglaea hums, rotating her ankle, propping her cheek on her fist as she considers. “Yes… Perhaps not. I can inquire with Tribios about finding other work for you. Perhaps you’d like to assist Hyacine in concocting medicines and preparing things in her infirmary?”

Castorice squirms. “I don’t believe I’m particularly suitable for that kind of work.”

“And why not?” Aglaea asks. “It’s not as if you can cause pain through inanimate objects, can you? A healing salve by your hand would be the same as one by Hyacine’s, assuming you use the proper ingredients.”

Phainon’s hand tightens around Mydei’s. He’s invested in this, just like he’d been that first day. Mydei has to admit that he is too.

“I suppose so,” Castorice admits, though she seems reluctant to believe it.

Aglaea waves her hand. “Think on it. There’s no rush to decide. We can search for more options if none of those appeal to you.”

“I…” Castorice’s eyes look wet. She opens her mouth to speak when there’s a groan from down the hall. This time it’s Cipher, coming out in a t-shirt and money printed pajama pants with perhaps the worst bedhead Mydei has seen on a person. She has Bubbles tucked happily in her arms, though she’s making a disgruntled face as she comes to join them.

“What infernal racket,” she complains, “I’m no Lady Goldweaver, but a cat’s ears are sensitive too, alright? What’s so important that you have to talk about it in the middle of the night?”

On her shoulder, Bubbles meows in agreement. When she notices them all staring, she scratches him on the head and adds, “What? He sleeps in my room now.”

Castorice just *stares.* Maybe she remembers Cipher drugging her, maybe she doesn't, but she seems a bit horrified by the catgirl's appearance. "Hello, Princess No-touchy," Cipher says to her. "It's wonderful to properly meet you, but some of us need our rest. Can I fluff your pillow so you can sleep extra cozy?"

"Cifera," Aglaea admonishes. Cipher makes a petulant sound.

"Yeah, yeah, sorry," she says, and falls into the other armchair. Bubbles settles in her lap, and Mydei can hear him purring, even from here. It's the strangest, most sickening betrayal he's ever experienced. She rubs circles into his ears and turns back to Castorice. "So. You staying?"

"I…"

"Please say yes," Cipher tells her. "I'm around too many boys all the time. And Aglaea is mean, so she doesn't count."

Castorice looks at Mydei now, absolutely helpless, and he can't stop the laugh that bursts out of him. Maybe he's just tired, but what the fuck? What a day. At his side, Phainon laughs too, and then they're all kind of laughing, even Castorice, though hers is awkward and nervous. The effort is there. Mydei thinks she'll fit right in.

△

In the end, Castorice decides to stay, though she decides to leave for tonight, if only for fear that Bubbles might get curious about her while she's sleeping and hurt himself. So Cipher and Aglaea go back to bed, and Mydei and Phainon walk her to the door.

"Goodnight, then," Mydei tells her, and she says it back, bowing her head politely.

"Can I count you as a friend?" Phainon asks, and her eyes widen a bit as she turns to him, inhaling.

"Friends," she breathes.

“Friends,” Phainon echoes back, smiling like some goddamn sun.

“It might be nice to have some, if you’re staying,” Mydei points out.

She smiles, a small, hesitant thing, and nods. “Friends,” she agrees, testing the feel of it in her mouth, like it’s a foreign thing to her. And maybe it is, but it doesn’t have to be. After a breath, Mydei holds out a hand.

“Should we shake on it?” he asks, and Castorice just stares at his hand like it's some kind of wild animal. He makes to lower it. “We don’t have to, if you don’t want.”

“No, I…” Her fingers twitch. “It might be nice,” she says, as Mydei had. Gingerly, she reaches out, then pauses before their hands can come in contact. "What if it stops working?" she croaks. “I don’t want—”

“My power is like yours,” Mydei explains. “It doesn’t just turn off and on. If it didn’t hurt the first time, it won’t hurt now.”

"Okay," Castorice says, and tentatively clasps his hand. Her grip is loose and uncertain, still gloved, the fabric a bit damp with cold sweat. She holds her breath as they shake once, and then she pulls her hand back, folding it toward her body and clearing her throat. It must be strange, scary, touching without consequence, but Mydei will let her take that at her own pace, if she decides she wants to.

“There,” he says simply. “It’s official.”

"Friends," Castorice says once more, like a broken record. She smiles a little. Mydei tries to smile back, wonders if it looks weird on his face.

“Maybe I’ll get one of those plastic mannequin hands,” Phainon interjects, “that way I can shake your hand too.”

Miraculously, this makes her laugh. A real, genuine laugh, high and girlish. Her smile crinkles her eyes. “Sure,” she says, “then you can all take turns shaking my hand, just so we can make it official.” Her voice is watery.

There’s a good chance she’ll cry when she returns to her own temporary home. Maybe not from sadness. Mydei doesn’t comment.

“Give us a few more days, and we’ll take care of the Cleaners for you too,” Phainon tells her. “We’ve been looking for a good lead on them for a long time. And then you won’t have much to be afraid of anymore.”

She looks tired, grateful. Mydei will be going on that mission too. Maybe he should be afraid, but he’s just… excited. Glad he’ll be useful, glad he can be there to have everyone else’s backs, glad to have the chance to do something good, for all the Castorices of the world.

“Thank you,” she says, voice breaking, now. Mydei could offer to hug her, but he won’t. Not for a long time, until he’s sure she’s ready for that. “Stay safe, please. They’re dangerous.”

“Aglaea and Anaxa came up with a plan,” Phainon tells her. “The plan never goes south when those two manage to get along long enough to work together.”

“Good,” she says, and turns halfway to the door. A brief pause, she looks between them. “I’ll… see you?”

“Of course,” Phainon says, easy as breathing, like that’s the most obvious thing in the world. Mydei envies the way he can make anyone feel comfortable.

“You will,” he agrees, and tries to smile again. Castorice smiles back, undoes the lock on the door, hand lingering on the knob.

“Goodnight,” she says again.

“Goodnight,” they echo back, and when the door shuts between them, it isn’t for long. She'll be back, Mydei knows. Strays calls to strays.

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